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No. 104

A CENTIMETRE A MONTH

ماهی یک سانت

CHEW Z

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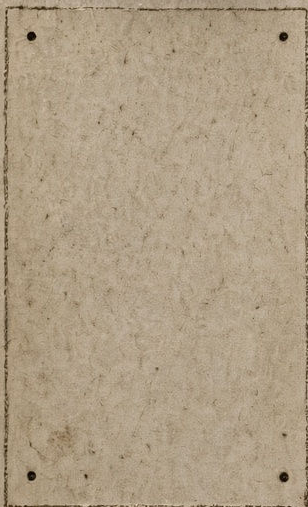
This is a work of fiction. The shop, the narrator and every character in it are invented. No person living or dead is depicted. The author's note sets out what is documented, and names the women the book itself could not.

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FROM THE UNSAID
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EIGHT OF THESE ARE DEPICTIONS OF HAIR.
THE NINTH IS HAIR.
ONE HAS BEEN REMOVED.

SYNOPSIS

A hair salon in southern Tehran has its street window painted over, because that is the law. Inside, every woman takes her scarf off. Outside, every woman puts it back on. It is the same women and the same four metres of ground, and the difference is a door.

A girl of fourteen comes to work at the back, washing hair. Her aunt gives her an old exercise book and tells her to write down what is there — how long it was, what was in it. The girl asks who wants it. Nobody wants it, her aunt says. Write it down anyway.

She is told she must cover her own hair so that men are not stirred. She cannot make the reason work, and for five years nobody will help her make it work.

And when her hands are in the water she begins to know, without wanting to and without being able to stop, what each head has already cost the woman wearing it. A morning. An afternoon in a van. Four years of six o'clock telephone calls. A room with no window. Two messages, one of them to somebody's father.

So the book in the drawer grows a second column, in smaller and smaller handwriting, and by the time she is nineteen it is the only place on earth where any of it has been added up.

Then a man comes to the shop with a folder, and he is polite, and he wants to know who started it.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

This book has no names in it. That is the point of it, and it is also the reason this note is longer than the ones at the front of the other books in this series.

Nothing in the story happened. The shop is invented, the girl is invented, her aunt is invented, and so are all five of the women whose accounts the book turns on. What she can do with her hands cannot be done.

What it cost them is not invented. Every price in that book is an ordinary price, of an ordinary kind, paid in that country by an enormous number of women whose names are written down nowhere.

But some names are written down, and this is where they go.

THE WOMEN THE BOOK COULD NOT NAME

On the sixth of Dey 1396 — the twenty-seventh of December 2017 — **Vida Movahed** stood on a utility box on Enghelab Street in Tehran, took off her white headscarf, tied it to a stick and held it up. She was thirty-one. She said nothing at all. She was arrested the same day. She had a nineteen-month-old daughter.

Over the following weeks other women did the same thing, alone, in Tehran and in other cities. Police reported twenty-nine arrests inside about a month. **Azam Jangravi** was one of the women who climbed up; she was dismissed from her job and later left the country.

And then the municipality welded inverted-V metal caps onto the tops of the utility boxes, so that the tops were no longer flat, so that nobody could stand on one. That is in this book because I have never been able to stop thinking about it. Somebody drew it. Somebody ordered the metal. Somebody was paid for a day's driving.

In Tir 1397 — July 2018 — **Maedeh Hojabri**, a teenager, was detained over videos of herself dancing that she had posted on Instagram, and was shown on state television saying she was sorry. Women across the country answered by posting videos of themselves dancing. Nobody organised that and there is no first name attached to it.

In Shahrivar 1398 — August 2019 — **Saba Kord Afshari** was sentenced to twenty-four years, **fifteen of them for taking off her headscarf in public**, the charge framed as spreading corruption and prostitution. She was twenty years old. The sentence was later reduced and she has since been released.

On the twenty-fifth of Shahrivar 1401 — the sixteenth of September 2022 — **Mahsa Jina Amini**, twenty-two years old, died in the custody of the guidance patrol in Tehran. What followed is not in this book, because this book stops a few weeks later, which is the point at which the girl telling it still knows nothing.

Not one of these women appears in the story. The series has a rule against it and I have never broken it. The narrator refuses to write Jina Amini's name for her own reasons, in her own entry, and those reasons are hers and not mine.

WHAT WOMEN HAVE SAID ABOUT IT THEMSELVES

I did not invent the feeling of the thing, and I want to be exact about where it came from.

Iran International interviewed Iranian women about the first time they went out in public with their heads uncovered. They described wind in their hair and cool air on the face and the neck, felt in public for the first time — in some cases at forty years old, in one case at sixty. One woman described crying while driving in a T-shirt, feeling air on her skin. A woman of forty said she wished she had felt it at twenty rather than at forty. A woman of seventy had stopped covering at sixty; another said it made her feel like a teenager again. The words they used were freedom, relief, lightness, power.

And beside that, the fear. Scarves carried in bags in case. Looking around constantly while walking. One woman's heart racing for the whole of a first outing.

One of them said something that is the engine of this entire book:

that seeing other women without headscarves gradually reduced her anxiety — that watching others make the same choice gave her more confidence.

She was made braver by strangers she never met and never thanked, and by walking past the next woman she made her braver in turn. That is what this book is about, and no part of it required anybody to organise anything.

Human Rights Watch published an interview by **Tara Sepehri Far** with a fifty-one-year-old woman given the pseudonym *Pendar*, who with two friends decided to walk crowded main streets uncovered on Wednesdays and Saturdays:

"We realized that hijab is the identity of Islamic Republic, so to speak. And we decided together that we will stop wearing it." > > "It was very scary and difficult for us at the beginning, but we decided to do it anyways and accepted all its consequences." > > "Schoolchildren would pass in their bus clapping and waving their hands for us. Now we get less of those." > > "There are still people who look at us in disgust."

Three friends deciding over tea is the largest unit of organisation anyone has documented in the whole of this change. I want that stated plainly, because it is the hardest fact in the file to believe and the most important one in the book.

Fatemeh Jamalpour, an Iranian journalist living in exile, said this on WBUR's *On Point*:

"This young generation made us a braver and better version of ourselves."

That sentence is why the girl telling this story is fourteen and the woman who teaches her is fifty-four. The usual direction of courage is reversed, and it is reversed in the record, not in my imagination.

WHERE THE BOOK'S FACTS COME FROM

The four interludes are the book's history and I am not going to tell it twice. What follows is where each of them comes from, so that a reader who wants to go and check can.

The first interlude — the oldest hair law, and the fact that it specified which women must cover and **forbade** the slave and the prostitute to, on pain of hot pitch — is the Middle Assyrian laws, roughly thirty-four centuries old. The old woman telling it does not know she is quoting a statute.

The second — that the two Qur'anic passages on covering do not contain the word for hair, and that hair was classified as *'awrah* later by juristic argument resting partly on a report whose chain of transmission has been disputed from inside the tradition — is a live argument and not a settled question. Sisters in Islam put the plain version publicly in 2015 and a mufti answered it within the week. Both positions are still standing. **The book states that it is an argument and takes no side, and neither do I.**

The third — Greek and Roman practice, the Mishnah, the letter about the angels, and the evidence that the preaching did not describe the street — rests on Grace Stafford's study of late antiquity, in which **only about a quarter of some hundred and fifty surviving female portrait sculptures show a covered head**, and in which the mosaics show the mistress covered and the attendant beside her bare.

The fourth — the map of where covering is law today — is Iran's Article 638; Afghanistan's decree of Ordibehesht 1401 and the virtue law of Sanbula 1403, whose Article 13 is quoted as the man quotes it; Aceh's provincial statute; and Sudan, 1989 to 2019.

WHAT THE BOOK DOES NOT SAY, AND I WILL

The forty years. Compulsory covering in Iran was not legislated at once. In 1357 it was presented as a recommendation and the protests of the eighth of March were answered by saying so. It was required in government offices within about a year and law by 1362. **There was no day on which anybody announced that the recommendation had become an order.** Then 1393. 1396, the utility boxes, the welded caps. 1397. 1398. Then Shahrivar 1401, and the guidance patrol's street function effectively ending that winter — after which, in Ordibehesht 1402, the judiciary drafted a Hijab and Chastity bill **because** the patrol had stopped. A parliamentary committee expanded it from fifteen articles to seventy-four. It passed. **And in Aban 1403 the Supreme National Security Council suspended it, and it has never been brought into force.** Nothing was repealed. The rule is still there.

Where the enforcement went. Not away — sideways. At least fifty business premises sealed across eight cities in 1404, with more in Borujerd and Kashan than in Tehran. Undercover officers announced for cafés and concerts. IMSI-catchers, contactless national-identity card readers and city cameras checked against government databases in Isfahan province, producing tens of thousands of warning messages — **sent to the woman and to her relatives.** That last clause is the whole of the fourth account in this book.

The figure everybody quotes. Women appearing without a headscarf after the 1401 uprising rose by **24 per cent** — from Avenia Ghazarian's working paper *Veils of Change*, cited by Mohammad Ali Kadivar in MERIP in Khordad 1405. **It measures appearances tracked on social media. It is not a street count and not a survey.** I would rather say that than repeat a number without saying what it is.

And the hair. Hair grows at a rate conventionally taken as about a centimetre a month, and what the body is doing is laid down in the shaft as it grows, which is why hair is used in research as a backwards-readable record of chronic stress over roughly the previous six months. And after a severe shock the follicles do not release the hair at once: they rest, and shedding begins **two to three months later.**

*Which means the hair does not come out during the crisis.
It comes out afterwards, when the thing is over and
everybody has stopped asking.*

That is the only reason the third account in this book exists. A woman's hair came out in the week her sister came home. **The body bills late, and it very often bills the woman who was not arrested.** The book never names any of this, because the girl telling it has no vocabulary for it and should not have.

WHAT I AM ARGUING, AND WHAT I AM NOT

The argument in this book — **that fear worked like a currency and that the state debased it by spending it, one woman at a time, for forty years** — is mine. It is not a finding. No researcher told me that. I think the book earns it, and you are entitled to disagree.

And I want to be straight about the opposite: **no source I could find says that the patrols stopped because they were overwhelmed by numbers.** Analysts read the easing as political calculation, including the calculation of not opening a second front during a war. **The government has never explained itself.** It is not explained in this book either.

What I will stand behind is the shape of it. Nothing was repealed. No retreat was announced. The rule is where it was, word for word, and the only thing between that street and the old price is that nobody has decided to start collecting again.

A thing nobody admits giving can be taken back without anybody admitting that either.

And the last thing, which is the reason I wrote it.

There was no leader. There was no plan, no committee, no first woman, no name for the man with the folder to write down. **And that is not the gentle version of this story. It is the hard one.** A movement with a leadership distributes its costs, keeps a roll of its dead, and can at least tell a woman that what happened to her was part of something.

This had none of that. **Every one of them paid the whole price by herself, for herself, and almost all of them were thanked by nobody, and there is no building anywhere whose job it is to add it up.**

That is what the second column is for.

Chew Z

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I. THE WINDOW

Khanom Ansari told me this in my first week, with her head over the basin and her eyes shut, because I had asked her a question and she was the only person who answered it instead of laughing.

She said: you think this started with us.

She said her own mother had told her that in the oldest places, long before anybody here prayed the way we pray, there was a law about hair. Not a law telling women to cover. A law telling them which women had to and which were forbidden.

A wife covered. A widow covered. They went out into the main road with their heads covered and everyone could see what they were.

And a woman who was owned, and a woman who sold herself, were not allowed to. Their heads had to be bare. That was the law. If one of them put something over her head and was caught, they poured hot pitch on her and beat her fifty times. And the man who saw her do it and said nothing to anybody, they beat him fifty times too, and put a hole through his ears so that people would know what he was.

I said, so the covering was to protect them.

She had soap on her forehead. I wiped it off with my thumb.

She said: child, think about what you just said. If it was to keep women safe from men, who would you cover first? The one with nobody. The one who is out at night. The one anybody can do anything to.

She said: they did not cover her. They forbade her. On pain of burning.

She said: so it was not a wall. It was a label. It was so that a man in the road could tell, without asking, whose you were.

Then she said the water was going cold, and I turned the tap, and she did not say anything else about it for four years.

1.

TO THE SHOULDER. A CLIP SHE HAD FORGOTTEN.

The first thing I learned in the shop was the window.

It is a big window onto the street and it has been painted over on the inside, cream, two coats, and over the paint there is a curtain that does not open. This is because the law says no man walking past may see a woman in here with her head uncovered.

We painted the window. Nobody painted the men.

My aunt put her hand flat on it the first morning and said, this is the law, and if a man out there can see in, they can shut me. I said who can. She said somebody can, and that is enough to know, which I have since learned is the single most accurate sentence anybody has ever said to me about this country.

On the wall behind the till there is a frame with a paper in it and a number on the paper, and the number is the licence. She renews it every year. She says if the number stops, the chairs are just chairs.

I have thought about that for five years and I have still not worked out which part of this is the religion and which part is the municipality.

I was fourteen. It was Dey and the pavements were wet. I had come to live with my aunt in the autumn because my mother had gone onto nights at the plant and could not do both ends of my school day. That is the reason I was given and I believed it for five years, which tells you something about me that will come up again.

Six chairs along the mirrors. Two dryers, one of which works. A tin of boiled sweets for children nobody brings.

My job was the basin.

There are two of them at the back under the hot pipe, with a dip in the porcelain where a neck goes. You learn the temperature first, and you test it on the inside of your wrist and not on your fingers, because fingers lie. Too hot and a woman says nothing and never comes back; too cold and she tells you at once, which is better. I got a head down to nine minutes inside a month and I would like that noticed, because nobody noticed it at the time.

Towel across the shoulders before the water, not after. Thumb above the ear so it goes back and not down. Ask twice — once at the start and once in the middle — and the second one is the one that counts, because the first one is manners.

And every woman who comes through that door takes her scarf off.

It took me years to notice that this was strange. Out on the pavement every head is covered. Inside, past the paint, every head is bare. **Same women. Same four metres of ground.** The entire difference is a door, a tin of cream paint, and a number in a frame.

There were six in by noon that first day and I washed four. My aunt cut three and did a colour and talked the whole time without stopping once — a wedding in Karaj, a cousin's car, the price of chicken — and the radio was on above the mirrors the way it is always on, a man reading something about the currency in the voice they keep for that.

The last one before lunch had a clip in her hair she had forgotten about, a little gold one with a bird on it. It came out in my hand under the water and she laughed and said her daughter had put it there in the morning and she had been walking round the whole district with a bird on her head and not one person had told her.

I have thought about that woman more than she would believe. She walked past the fruit shop and the pharmacy and the bakery with a bird on her head, in a country where what is on a woman's head is a matter for the government, **and the government did not notice the bird.**

When she had gone my aunt gave me a school exercise book with a cardboard cover. Not new. It had somebody's sums in the front, which she tore out.

She said: write down what's there.

I said what do you mean, what's there.

She said: the hair. How long it was. Anything in it.

I said for what. Does somebody want it.

And she said no. Nobody wants it. Write it down anyway.

So I wrote **to the shoulder, a clip she had forgotten**, and I put the book in the drawer under the till next to the appointment book, and I did not think about it again for a week, and that is the first line of a document that a man from the government took away from me five years later, because he wanted a name and it has none in it.

2.

DOWN HER BACK, AND NOT ONE GREY HAIR AT FIFTY-SIX.

I am not going to use many names in this.

Partly that is the book's fault — there are no names in it, not one, in five years, in nearly four hundred entries, and after that long you stop reaching for them. And partly it is that a shop does not work by names. A shop works by slots. The woman who comes every second Thursday. The first Saturday of the month. The one who always wants it done before a Friday and always says she does not mind waiting and always minds.

So that is how they will come, and I am not going to pretend it is modesty.

My aunt does not get a name either. She is Khaleh. That is a word for your mother's sister and it is the only thing I have ever called her, including once in an office, in front of a man, when a name would have been more use. **And the man who came for the book at the end of all this does not get one, because he is the only person in this account who had the power to write mine down, and I have decided he can go without.**

That winter it was the money.

I did not understand the money. What I understood was bread, because I bought the bread — that the number on the note in my pocket stayed where it was and the loaf got smaller, and that nobody had announced it, and that there was no day on which it had happened.

What they argued about was whose fault it was.

The woman who comes every second Thursday said it was the Americans. She said it the way you say a thing you have read your whole life. I would like to record that the Americans have been in that shop every second Thursday for five years and have never once had their hair done.

Khanom Ansari, who came on the first Saturday, said it was ours, meaning the government's, and said it flatly, the way old people say a thing they have said many times and have given up expecting to be contradicted.

Somebody said it was the last lot. Somebody else said it was the lot before them. One woman — she only came twice, I never found out what she was called — said can everybody please be quiet for one minute, I want to hear the end of this.

Nobody won.

Nothing in that room ever finished. Somebody would say the sentence that ought to have ended it, and then a dryer would go on, and twenty minutes later it would start again from the beginning in a different mouth with the same opinion. In five years I never once saw a woman in that shop change her mind about anything except a colour.

And here is the part that took me longer. **We were not arguing with anybody.** There was nobody in the room to argue with. The government was never in that shop. It was on the radio, and it was in the frame on the wall, and it was in the paint on the window, and it never once had to come in and sit down and answer a question.

I said that to my aunt on the walk home. I said which one of them is right.

She said about the money?

I said about any of it.

She said: Baran, in this country you can be right for forty years and it makes no difference to one single thing. Then she said we needed eggs.

That was also the month I asked my question for the first time, at the basin, with my hands in somebody's hair.

I said: why do I have to cover my hair.

She said: because that is the rule.

I said: I know it's the rule. Why is it the rule.

And she said: so that men don't get ideas.

So I thought about that properly, because I am a literal person and it was offered as a reason.

I am in charge of the contents of a stranger's head. Not my head. His. There is a man somewhere in this city I have never met and never will, and his thoughts are my department. I have held the post since I was nine. Nobody interviewed me. There is no training, the hours are every hour I am outside the house, there is no overtime, and the only performance review is conducted in the street by whoever feels like it.

And if he has the thought anyway it is still my fault, because the job has no upper limit and no definition of success.

I said: then it is the men.

She did not hear me, or she heard me and let it go, which with her is the same thing.

The woman in the chair had hair all the way down her back and was fifty-six years old and did not have one grey hair in it, not one, and I wrote that down because it was the most interesting thing that happened to me that day.

3.

CUT TO THE JAW THAT MORNING, BY HERSELF, BADLY.

In Bahman a woman stood on top of one of the grey metal boxes on a pavement in the middle of town, the kind with cables in it, and took her scarf off and tied it to a stick and held it up over her head.

She did not shout anything. That was the part the shop could not get past. She did not say one word. She stood up there and held it up and let people look.

They took her away the same day.

Then over the next weeks other women did it. Here and in two other cities. On boxes, on a bollard, on a wall. Each one alone. Each one quiet. Each one taken away.

And then they welded the caps on.

Somebody went out with a van and a welder and put a metal peak on the top of every one of those boxes in the district, a little roof, so the top is not flat any more. So there is nowhere to stand.

I walked past them for years and never got used to it, and I want to set out what I admire about it, because I do admire it.

They did not take the boxes away, or put a camera on them, or post a man. **They changed the shape of the top of the box so that a woman cannot stand on it.**

Somebody drew that. Somebody sat down with a pencil and worked out the angle. Somebody costed the metal and somebody signed off the costing and somebody was paid for a week's driving. Somewhere in this city there is a man who had a week where his job was boxes, and I think about him more often than I think about several of my relatives, and what I want to know is what he said at dinner.

Because you cannot say nothing. You come home and somebody asks what you did today.

And it worked. That is the other thing. Nobody has stood on one since.

So the first lesson this country ever taught me about itself was not about women and it was not about God. It was that if you make the top of the box pointy, the problem goes away, **and nobody has to have an argument with anybody.**

That was also the week my aunt burned the books.

She did it on a Thursday night in the yard, in the half-barrel the man downstairs uses for rubbish, in her indoor slippers, and I came down because I could smell it from the window.

Eighteen years of appointment books. The fat kind with the ring binding, one a year, and every page of every one of them is names. Names and dates and times. Who sat in that chair, on which afternoon, at what hour.

I said Khaleh, what are you doing.

She said go up.

I said those are the books.

She said I know what they are. Go up.

I stood on the step and watched her feed them in one at a time and push them down with a stick when they went slack, and she did not cry and she did not hurry, and when it was done she washed her hands at the tap in the yard for a long time.

In the morning there was a brand new appointment book in the drawer with nothing in it, and my exercise book beside it, and she pushed the exercise book towards me with two fingers and said, you keep that one.

I did not ask her why for five years.

That was not restraint. I was fourteen, and the adults around me did things, and some of them were strange, and you did not interrogate it any more than you interrogated the weather. My aunt burning eighteen years of her own paperwork in a barrel went into the same part of my head as my mother's shifts and the water going off on Tuesdays.

She came in at noon that day with her hair cut to the jaw. She had done it herself in the night with the kitchen scissors, badly, and she would not let anybody fix it.

I wrote that down. **Cut to the jaw that morning, by herself, badly.**

I thought she was upset about the news.

4.

TO THE WAIST. CAME IN BRAIDED AND WOULD NOT LET ME UNDO IT.

Esfand is the worst month and the best month, because everybody wants to be new for the year. We did fourteen heads one Wednesday and I did not sit down between eight in the morning and nine at night, and my aunt gave me more money at the end of it than I had ever held, and I spent it on a scarf for my mother, which I am aware of.

There are two books in the drawer under the till and I should set out what the other one is, because later it matters.

Here is what the appointment book is. A woman telephones or leans in the door, and you write her name and the day and the time and what she wants. That is all. Every shop in the country has one. The bakery has one. It is the most ordinary object in any business anywhere.

And here is the other thing it is, which I did not see for years.

It is a list of every woman in this district who has sat in that room with nothing on her head, and the date she did it, and the hour.

Nobody keeps it for that. Nobody looks at it that way. It is appointments. But if a person ever wanted such a list, there would be no need to go and build one, because the law already requires a woman like my aunt to keep it, in a drawer, in a shop with a painted window, and to be able to produce it when asked.

I want to be fair here, because I have had five years to work out who to blame for that and the answer is nobody. Nobody designed it. **It is just what happens when you make a room where the rule is suspended and then put a number on the wall.** You cannot have the exception without the paperwork. The paperwork is the price of the exception.

In Esfand I started filling the exercise book in properly, every head, not only the interesting ones. It took about forty seconds. I did it standing at the till while the dryer ran.

To the shoulder. To the waist. Short at the back and long at the front, which was the thing that year. Grey underneath and black on top. Thin at the crown, and she knows, and does not want it mentioned.

A woman came in on the last Thursday with her hair in one plait to her waist and would not let me undo it to wash. Her mother had plaited it that morning and her mother was not well and she wanted to keep it until Friday. So I washed around it, which cannot actually be done, and we both pretended it had worked, which is the most Iranian forty minutes of my life.

I wrote her down. One line. **To the waist, came in braided and would not let me undo it.**

There was nothing else to write. There was no second line yet. For the first part of that book there is only ever one line, and when I look at those pages now, the white space under each of them is the loudest thing on the paper.

5.

TO THE SHOULDER, AND THE SAME PARTING SHE HAS HAD ALL HER LIFE.

Khanom Ansari came at ten on the first Saturday of every month and had done since before I was born.

She was about seventy. She wore grey. She carried a cloth bag with a zip and had the exact money folded in her hand before she sat down, which my aunt said she had done for twenty years, and which my aunt said was a thing people of that generation do so as never to owe anybody anything for even one minute.

Her hair came to her shoulder. Thin, very clean, set rather than cut, and the parting on the left.

That parting is in my book more times than anything else in it, because she came every month for four and a half years and it never moved. Not a centimetre. I used to wet it and comb it and watch it fall back into the same line as though the line had been cut into her scalp.

I thought it was just how old ladies are.

She was the only person who ever answered my question. Everybody else either laughed, or said because that is the rule, or said because men are animals — which is offered as a defence of the men, and I would like somebody to sit down and look at that sentence properly one day — or said you will understand when you are older, which is what people say when they do not know and have decided that time will cover for them.

Khanom Ansari asked me what I had actually meant by it. That is all she did. And when I had explained it badly for about a minute she shut her eyes and told me the thing about the old law, the one about which women had to cover and which were forbidden, and the hot pitch, and the man with the hole through his ears.

And then she said the thing I did not understand for three years. She said: it was not a wall, child. It was a label.

I wrote down **to the shoulder, and the same parting she has had all her life**, which I now think is the most informative line in the entire book, and which I wrote because I had nothing else to say about her.

I liked her and I want that in here, because the way I have described her so far makes her sound like a wise old woman out of a story and she was nothing of the kind. She was a ferocious gossip. She had views on a serial she watched with the sound off at our place and narrated herself, including the parts she had invented. She once told a woman in the next chair, to her face, with no preamble, that her son was a waste of a good education. She called my aunt's coffee an insult and she said it every month for four and a half years and my aunt kept making it the same way, and I have never decided which of them was winning.

She did not talk about herself. In four and a half years, not once, not one fact.

It was the hottest week of the following summer before I knew a single thing about her life, and I did not get it out of her mouth.

6.

THIN AT THE LEFT TEMPLE, AND IT HAS NOT CAUGHT UP.

She was in a van once. It was years ago. She has not let anybody touch her head since.

This is the entry where the book changes and I want to put down exactly what happened, in order, because for a long time I thought I had made it up.

It was the middle of Farvardin. The year was new. The shop was quiet in the way it goes quiet after Nowruz, when everybody has already had their hair done and nobody has any money left.

A woman came in at about four in the afternoon who had not been in before. Forties. A green coat. She stood just inside the door for longer than people stand there.

My aunt did her consultation at the chair, which is the normal thing — you sit them down, you talk about what they want, you lift the hair at the sides. And then she walked her back to the basin and handed her to me, and said, Baran will take care of you, in the voice she uses for people who are nervous, which is a different voice from her ordinary one.

The woman sat down. I put the towel across her shoulders. I asked her to lean back.

And she did not lean back.

She sat forward with her hands in her lap and she looked at the taps. I waited. My aunt was at the mirrors with her back to us doing somebody's roots and I could see in the glass that she was watching.

After a while the woman said, I do this myself, normally.

I said, that's all right.

She said, I have done it myself for a long time.

I said, you can keep your head up if you like, some people prefer it, I can do it with a jug.

And she thought about that and then she said no, it's fine, and she leaned back, and she put her neck into the dip in the porcelain, and I turned the water on and put my hand in her hair.

And I knew.

I am going to try to say this properly and it is going to sound mad, and I have no interest in persuading anybody.

It was not a picture. Nothing went dark and nothing flashed and there was no voice. It was more like the way you know your own telephone number — you do not look it up, you do not work it out, you do not remember it; it is simply there, and if somebody asks you for it, it comes out of your mouth.

What was there was this. **That she had been put into a van, once, a long time ago. That they had taken hold of her hair to get her into it. And that she had not let another human being touch the back of her head since the week it happened.**

That was all. No van in my head, no scene — three facts sitting in me the way the number sits in you, with no edges and nothing attached, and I had not had them two seconds earlier.

My hands kept going. That is the part I think about. My hands did not stop. I rinsed her and I asked is it still good and she said yes, and I did the second wash, and I did the ends, and I wrapped her and walked her up to the chair, and I said nothing at all.

And then I went and stood by the back door with the yard in front of me and shook.

I told myself I had made it up. Out of the way she sat, and the green coat, and the shop going flat about the boxes, and being fourteen and reading too much into things. I was extremely reasonable about it for three weeks. **I have since noticed that I am at my most reasonable when I have decided in advance what the answer is going to be, which is a thing I learned off the radio.**

I did not write the second line that day. The page for the fifteenth of Farvardin has one line on it, **thin at the left temple**, and nothing under it.

I wrote the second line in Mordad, four months later, when I knew. You can see it. The ink is different and the hand is worse, because by then my hand was worse.

7.

SHORT, AND GOING WHITE AT THE FRONT ONLY.

Nothing. She has never been stopped in her life and she does not know that is unusual.

It happened again in Ordibehesht and then it happened again eight days later and after that I stopped being able to call it nothing.

So I tested it, which I am not proud of.

There was the woman who came every second Thursday, the one who thought it was the Americans. I knew a certain amount about her from the room, the way you do — a husband, two sons, a sister in Mashhad, a knee that needed doing. So I washed her and I waited to see whether what came was anything I could have got from the chairs.

Nothing came. Nothing at all. I had my hands in her hair for seven minutes and there was no number and no fact, and I stood there feeling faintly insulted, as though she were holding something back out of meanness. Then I understood, and I had to put the water on cold and hold my wrists under it.

Nothing came because there was nothing. She had never been stopped. Not once, not in fifty-nine years, not even leaned out of a car at. She had got all the way through her whole life inside the rule and the rule had never once put its hand on her, and she did not know that this was a remarkable thing to be able to say, because why would she. Nobody compares.

I wrote **nothing** on the second line and I looked at it for a while.

My aunt saw me looking at it. She did not ask what I was writing. In five years she never once asked me what was on the second line, and she never once looked, and I know she never looked because the book stayed exactly where I left it, and I am the sort of person who notices a book that has been moved.

She did say one thing, that spring, out of nowhere, with her back to me.

She said, you do not have to put everything in there.

And I said, I know.

And she said, I am saying you do not have to. Then she went and dealt with somebody's foils.

I have turned that over for years. I think she was telling me I was allowed to stop. I think she was also telling me she knew what I had started. Both of those can be true of her at the same time; that is what she is like.

In Khordad the heat arrived and the question came back, and this time it came back with teeth.

Because here is Tir and Mordad in this city. Forty degrees and more. The shop is a closed room with two dryers and a hot pipe along the back wall. I worked in there in a long tunic with sleeves to the wrist and a scarf pinned at the throat, and I walked home in it, and I stood at the bus stop in it with the pavement going soft under me.

And the reason — the entire reason, the whole and only reason — is so that a man I have never met does not have a thought.

I have costed this. In Tir I am wearing about four hundred grams of cloth I do not need, in a room at forty-four degrees, for nine hours a day, six days a week, and the fan has not worked since the Wednesday before. And the entire return on that, the whole of what the country gets for it, is **the uninterrupted inner life of a man on a bus.**

I would like it recorded that the fan is the part I find hardest to forgive. A thing I could have fixed. Forty years of this and nobody has fixed the fan.

I said it to my aunt again at the end of a Thursday, with my shirt stuck to my back.

I said, Khaleh, if a man can't walk past my head without getting an idea, what exactly is wrong with me.

And she said, nothing is wrong with you.

And I said, then it is the men.

And she stopped with her hand on the light switch and she looked at me for a second longer than she needed to, and then she turned the light off and said, lock the back.

8.

LONG, DYED A RED THAT IS NOT A HUMAN COLOUR, AND SHE LOVES IT.

Nothing. A fine for the car once, which she says does not count.

I want to say what the shop was actually like, because if I only put the heavy things down it will come out as something it was not.

It was the funniest room I have ever been in.

The radio would be saying something about the currency and the second-Thursday woman would be saying it was the Americans and a woman under the dryer would be shouting that she could not hear and did anybody know whether the water was going off on Tuesday, and in the middle of all of it somebody would say one thing about somebody's son-in-law and the whole room would go. Properly go. Four women with wet heads laughing until one of them had to take her glasses off.

They talked about weddings for forty minutes at a time. Not the marriage. The catering. Who had been slighted over the seating. What a certain mother-in-law had worn and what she had said she had paid for it and what she had actually paid for it.

They talked about football. There was a woman who came in with her nephew's team's results written on the back of her hand because she could not keep them in her head and she wanted to be able to argue.

They talked about drivers. Everybody in that room held the same absolute conviction, which is that the drivers in this city are the worst in the world, and specifically the ones from one particular district, which would be named; and whoever in the room was from that district would say something unrepeatable; and off it would go again. **In five years that was the only subject on which the shop reached unanimity, and it was wrong.**

And the food. God. There would be an argument about rice that had been running for three visits.

I am putting this in because of a thing I noticed later. Of all the heads in my book, most of the second lines say nothing. Most of those women had not been stopped. Most of them went out in the morning with a scarf on their head the way you go out with shoes on your feet, and it did not cost them one thought, and they were perfectly happy, and they talked about catering.

The woman with the red hair came in that summer. It was a red that does not exist on any animal. She had been doing it for years and her daughters were embarrassed by it and she did not care in the slightest.

Her second line says nothing, except a fine for the car, which she said did not count because everybody gets those.

She was in the chair when the radio said something about a court and a sentence, and the room went quiet for about four seconds, and then she said, in that case I'm having it redder, and the whole shop fell apart.

I wrote her down laughing. I remember my handwriting on that one is bad because my hand was shaking from laughing, and for a long time afterwards I could not tell, looking at the page, whether my hand had been shaking from that or from the other thing.

9.

SET, NOT CUT. THE SAME PARTING ON THE LEFT.

A morning. One scarf she did not have with her. Twenty-two years.

It was the first Saturday in Tir and it was the hottest day of that summer and the fan in the back had stopped working two days before and nobody had come to look at it.

Khanom Ansari came at ten with her money folded in her hand.

I had washed her head once a month for a year and a half by then and nothing had ever come. Not one thing. I had decided she was like the second-Thursday woman — that she had got all the way through and the rule had never put its hand on her — and I had decided it with a kind of relief, because I liked her.

That morning my hands were not right. It was the heat. I ran the water too hot and she said so, and I brought it down, and she settled her neck into the dip and shut her eyes.

And I put my hand flat on the back of her head, under the hair, which is a thing you do to lift it off the porcelain.

And it came in like a wall.

That she had worked in an office of a ministry. That she had been there nine years. That one morning the women were called in and told. That she did not have a scarf with her that day. That she was sent home at ten in the morning to fetch one. And that she was not let back in.

Twenty-two years of service. A pension she never drew one month of.

I stood there with my hand under her head and the water running over my wrist and did not move for long enough that she opened her eyes and looked up at me.

She said, what.

And I said nothing. I washed her hair and did the second wash and towelled her and walked her to the chair, and my aunt took over, and I went out into the yard and sat on the step in the forty degrees with my back against the wall.

Here is what she told me afterwards, in her own words, because I asked her. I went and sat down next to her at the mirrors while her set was going off and I said, Khanom Ansari, were you ever in an office.

And she looked at me in the glass for a second and then she told me, and it took about four minutes, and it is the only time in four and a half years that she said anything about herself.

She said: at the beginning nobody said it was compulsory.

She said: they said it was a recommendation. That is the word. A recommendation. There were women in the street about it and the answer that came back was that nobody had ordered anything, it was advice, and a great many people were satisfied with that, including me, because I wanted to be.

She said: by the next year you could not come through the door of the building without it. Not a rule on a wall. Nobody put up a notice. The man at the door simply did not let you through, and there was nobody to appeal to, because officially nothing had changed.

She said: and about four years after that it was the law. And I want you to understand, child, that not on one single day in those four years did anybody stand up anywhere and say, we have decided that the recommendation is now an order. There was no such day. I have looked for it my whole life. It does not exist.

She said: so that is how it happens. Not with an announcement. With a door.

I have thought about that sentence more than any other sentence anybody has said to me. **Nobody in this country has ever been told anything. We have been let through doors, or not.**

Then she said: and I was sent home at ten o'clock in the morning for a piece of cloth.

I said, but you came back the next day.

And she said, no.

I said, you went back, though. With a scarf. Everyone did.

And she said: I went back with a scarf. There was a different man at the door and my pass had been stopped and he was very polite about it. He said there was a letter coming. I waited for the letter for a year.

She said: I was thirty-one. I never worked again.

And then the dryer went on and she shut her eyes, and that was the end of it, and she came back on the first Saturday of the next month with her money folded in her hand.

10.

THE PARTING AGAIN. IT HAS NOT MOVED IN FORTY YEARS.

And she cannot type. Her hands are perfectly good.

There were two more things about Khanom Ansari and she did not tell me either of them. I had them from the water and then I watched for them for years afterwards and they were both true.

The first is the parting.

Forty years on the left, in the same line, never a centimetre either way. I had written it down a dozen times without once asking myself why a woman would do that.

Here is why. The last time she presented herself to the world looking different from the way she had looked the day before, she lost her entire working life before lunch. She went in at eight, she was on the street at ten, and she was never let back in.

So she never did it again. Not the parting, not the colour, not the length, not the coat. For forty years she has gone out of her front door looking exactly the way she looked the day before, and she has never been able to explain to anybody why, because she does not know it herself. She told my aunt once that she had never suited anything else, which is not true. I have seen a photograph.

That is what her hair kept. A head of hair grows about a centimetre a month, so there is a sense in which there is nothing left on her head that was there on that morning. It has all been replaced many times over. The hair is new. **The line is not.**

The second thing is the typing.

She cannot type.

There is nothing the matter with her hands. She knits, badly but at speed. She counts money like a teller. She can thread a needle without her glasses, at seventy, which my aunt could not do at fifty.

My cousin had an old machine, the kind with the carriage, and it sat on a table at a family thing one Friday, and Khanom Ansari was there, and somebody said, Khanom, you were a typist, show them. And she sat down at it.

And nothing happened.

She put her hands on it in the right position, with the thumbs where thumbs go, which showed that nine years were still in there somewhere. And then she sat with her hands on the keys and did not press any of them. For a while. Long enough that people stopped watching and started talking about something else to be kind.

Then she got up and said the ribbon was dry.

The ribbon was not dry. I checked afterwards, because I was that sort of child.

That is what her body kept. Not a bad back, not a scar, nothing anyone would write down anywhere. She simply cannot do the thing she was good at, forty years later, in a room full of her own family, on a Friday.

I wrote the two lines in the book that night at the kitchen table.

The parting again. It has not moved in forty years.

And she cannot type. Her hands are perfectly good.

And then I sat there for a long time, because I had just understood what I had in the drawer.

I had been writing down, for a year and a half, the first column. How long it was. What was in it. The thing anybody can see from the pavement, the thing the window is painted over for, the thing the law is about.

And the second column was what it had cost. And the second column was in nobody's book anywhere. Not in a court, not in an office, not in a newspaper. Khanom Ansari's twenty-two years are not written down in any building in this country. There is no file that says what that morning took. There is no number. Her pension is not a number that exists and was not paid; it is a thing that was never a number at all.

Except that it was now in a school exercise book with a cardboard cover, in a drawer under a till, in a shop with a painted window, in the handwriting of a girl of fifteen.

I would like somebody to explain to me how it is that the only ledger in this country with that figure in it was kept by **a person who was not trusted to do a cut.**

11.

TO THE SHOULDER, AND SHE ASKED ME TO TAKE A HAND'S WIDTH OFF.

Nothing. Two of her daughters, nothing. The third one she will not discuss.

I did not tell anybody. I want to set down why, because at fifteen I thought about it quite hard and I think the reasons were the right ones even though they were not kind to me.

I did not tell my mother because my mother worked nights and when she was home she slept, and because the one thing my mother wanted was for me to be a girl with no complications.

I did not tell my aunt because of the night in the yard with the barrel. I had seen what she did with eighteen years of names. I understood, in a way I could not have put in words, that in that family you did not hand someone a thing they would then have to carry.

And I did not tell a friend because I was fifteen and I knew exactly what would happen. It would be a game by Thursday.

So I kept it, and the keeping of it is the thing that actually changed me, more than the knowing.

Because it is useless. I cannot warn anybody; there is nothing to warn them about, it has already happened. I cannot prove anything, and I cannot help one single woman with it, and I cannot even talk to them about it, because the one thing every one of them has in common is that they did not choose to tell me.

It only works backwards. It tells me the price after it has been paid, when there is nothing left to do about the price. **I have been given the one talent in the world that is purely administrative.**

And it does not get easier. People say you get used to things. I got worse.

And it only ever happens with women, because women are the only people I wash. There is a barber two doors down with a striped pole and I have never once been inside it. So everything in my book is one-sided. Everything in it was paid by one half of the people on my street.

I have thought about that a great deal and I have never once wished I could read the other half.

The woman that Saturday had three daughters and she asked me to take a hand's width off because of the heat, and my aunt let me do the cut, which was the first one she ever let me do, and it was not good but it was not bad.

Two of her daughters had cost her nothing. Nothing at all, not a stop, not a word.

And the third one was there and would not come near the water, and sat by the door the whole time with her bag on her knees looking at the painted window, and did not take her scarf off, inside, in a women's shop, in Tir, in forty degrees.

I did not write her down. She was not a head. She was a girl sitting by a door.

I have thought since that she is the only person in the entire book who got away from me, and that she is probably the reason I kept going.

12.

ALL ONE LENGTH, TO THE JAW, GROWN OUT AND LEFT.

Nothing that I could read. Nothing at all, from her, in four years.

The last Thursday in Mordad we shut at nine and the street was still warm enough that the shutters ticked when they came down.

We walked home the long way because my aunt wanted cigarettes and the man on the corner by the bakery is the only one who still sells them singly.

I had my scarf on. She had hers on. Everybody on that pavement had hers on; it was not a thing you noticed any more than you notice that the cars are on the right.

She smoked about a third of it and gave the rest to a man sitting on the step outside the pharmacy, which she did every time, and which in five years neither of them ever mentioned. **I have watched two people conduct an entire relationship on two-thirds of a cigarette.**

And she said, how is the book.

I said, fine.

She said, how many.

I said I did not know, a few hundred, and she said, hm.

And I said, Khaleh, why do you want me to do it.

And she said: I don't want you to do it. I want it done.

That is exactly what she said. I have had four years to decide what it meant and I had it wrong for all four of them. At fifteen I thought she was being my aunt — that it was one of those jobs adults invent for you, like counting the towels, so that you have something to be in charge of.

Her own hair was all one length to the jaw that summer, grown out from the night in the bathroom with the kitchen scissors and left alone, and when I washed it, which I did every second week for four years, nothing came. Nothing at all. In four years I never got one single fact about my aunt out of the water, and I decided that this meant she was like the second-Thursday woman.

I was fifteen and I had a book in a drawer with a few hundred heads in it, and under more than half of them it said nothing, and under the rest of them it said things like a morning, and a van, and twenty-two years.

I did not know yet that it was a bill. I thought it was a list.

And I did not know why my aunt cut her hair to that exact length, or why she had it cut to that exact length again six weeks later, and again six weeks after that, and again, and again, for every year I was in that shop, and why she would stand at the mirror afterwards with her head slightly on one side and look at it for a moment too long, and then say, right, and go and put the kettle on.

I watched her do that perhaps forty times. I never once asked.

II. THE SECOND COLUMN

There was a woman who came in on Mondays who had taught for thirty years, and one Monday in Dey she said a thing to me very quietly, with the dryer going two chairs down, and then never said anything like it again for the rest of the time I knew her.

I had asked her my question. By then I asked everybody. I had got used to the laughing.

She did not laugh. She looked at the mirror and not at me and she said: do you know what the book actually says.

I said I thought I did.

She said: there are two places. In one of them it says that women should draw their coverings over their chests. In the other it says they should be known, so that they are not troubled.

She said: that is it. That is the whole of it. Two places.

Then she said: now tell me which word in either of those is the word for hair.

I did not say anything.

She said: there isn't one. The word is not there. Not in the first and not in the second. You can look. People do look. It is not a secret and it is not a trick.

She said: hair came afterwards. Men who studied the law for a living worked it out later, out of other things, and some of them disagreed with each other, and some of them leaned on a report that other scholars — their own, not foreigners — have argued about ever since on the grounds that the chain of people who passed it down does not hold up.

She said: and that argument has never been settled. It is not settled now. There are people of faith in this very city, good ones, who will tell you the hair was never in it, and there are people of faith who will tell you it obviously was, and both of them can give you their reasons, and I am not going to tell you which of them is right because I do not know.

Then she said: I am telling you that it is an argument. That is all I am telling you. Most people your age are brought up to think it is not one.

And then she said, in a completely different voice: is that water going cold?

It was not going cold. I turned it anyway.

Three weeks later I washed her hair and found out what it had cost her, in her life, over thirty years, to be a woman who knew that and mostly did not say it. And she had not told me and never did tell me, and I never once let on.

13.

TO THE SHOULDER, GOING GREY AT THE TEMPLES AND SHE IS LETTING IT.

Nothing.

I was fifteen when school started again and by then the book had two lines on every page and I had worked out how to do it.

You do not write it at the basin. You cannot; your hands are wet and there is a woman in front of you with her eyes shut. You carry it. You carry it up to the chair and you hand her over and you go to the till and you write two lines while the dryer runs, and it takes about forty seconds, and then you go and do the next one.

The first line I write straight. How long, what colour, what was in it, what she asked for.

The second line I write as short as I can get it.

I found that out by accident. In the beginning I wrote the second line properly, in sentences, the way you would tell somebody. And after a few weeks I could not read my own pages without having to put the book down. So I cut them. Not to hide anything — the book is not in code, anybody could read it — but because **a morning** is something you can write and **four days** is something you can write, and the long version is something you have to live through again at the till with a dryer going.

So the second column of that book is the shortest writing I have ever done. Some of it is one word. **I have since been told that this is a style. It is not a style. It is what you can get down before you have to look up and smile at somebody.**

Nothing.

That is the most common entry in the whole book. I want to keep saying that because it is true and because it is the thing I would not have believed before I started.

More than half of the women who sat in that chair had never been stopped, never been spoken to, never had a hand put on them, never been photographed, never had a letter, never had a message. They went out in the morning with a scarf on the way you go out with shoes on. It cost them nothing. They were not brave and they were not cowards; it had simply never come up.

And there is no way to tell them apart. That is the thing. You cannot look at a room of six women with wet heads and see which two of them are the ones.

Which I would like to put beside something the radio says often, which is that a person who has done nothing has nothing to fear. **I have a book that proves the opposite with dates in it.**

The woman that first Monday was letting the grey come in at the temples, deliberately, against her daughter's advice, which she reported to the whole shop with great satisfaction.

Her second line says nothing.

I wrote it and I was glad, and then I noticed that I had been glad, and that noticing is the thing that changed me more than any of it. Because to be glad that a page says nothing is to have accepted what the other pages are.

14.

LONG, AND SHE HAD IT UP ALL DAY FOR WORK AND WANTED IT DOWN.

A warning, years ago, on paper, for something her brother did. She kept it.

That autumn they arrested a girl for dancing.

She was about my age, maybe a year older. She had been putting up short films of herself dancing in her bedroom, the way everybody does, hundreds of them, nothing in them at all. And they took her, and they put her on the television saying she was sorry.

I watched it with the sound off because the sound is always off in the shop. You could see her face.

I would like somebody to walk me through the meeting. Because a room of adults sat down with a problem, and the problem was that a schoolgirl had danced in her bedroom, **and the solution they arrived at was national broadcast.**

And then over the next days women started putting up films of themselves dancing. Thousands of them. Old women. Women in kitchens. A woman in a hospital uniform in a corridor. Two sisters in a garden with a hose going. My own cousin, who cannot dance.

Nobody organised it. I want to be accurate about that, because at the time it felt like something enormous, like a thing with a shape, and years later I went looking for who had started it and there is no answer. There is no name. Somebody did it and then somebody else did it.

They spent a television channel on one girl and got back several thousand girls. If a week went like that in our shop my aunt would have shut early and gone through the order book to find out where it had gone wrong.

The shop was split and it was split in a way I did not expect.

The second-Thursday woman said the girl was a fool and that her mother must be dying of it.

A woman whose name I never got said what exactly do you expect them to do, they cannot have every girl in the country in her bedroom on a telephone.

And a woman in the end chair, who was about sixty and had said nothing all morning, said: when I was that age they would not have put her on the television. They would have just kept her.

And the room went quiet, because that was true, and because nobody wanted it to be the thing that was said.

Then somebody asked about the water going off on Tuesday and it went again.

Nobody won. Nobody in that shop in five years ever won one of those. The same six opinions, in different mouths, for four and a half years, and not one of them ever got within a mile of a person who could do anything about any of it.

The woman at the basin that day had kept a warning letter for years in a tin. It was not even hers. It had come about her brother. She had kept it because it had her family's name on it and she did not trust herself to remember the exact wording.

15.

SHORT AND PRACTICAL, AND SHE HAS WORN IT LIKE THAT SINCE SHE WAS FORTY.

Thirty years of saying almost nothing. Two transfers. A room at the back of a building with no window.

Three weeks after she told me about the two verses, I washed the teacher's hair.

She came on Mondays at twenty past ten and she had a bad hip and she liked the water hotter than anybody else in the book.

And what came was not an event. That is why this one is in here. There is no van and no morning and no letter. There is no moment at all. What came was **thirty years of a woman keeping her mouth almost shut, and the two times she did not.**

The first time was early and she was young and it was not even about this. It was about a text she had taken out of a lesson because she thought it was too hard for the class, and somebody reported that she had taken it out, and she was moved to another school across the city with an hour and a half each way.

The second time was years later and I do not know what she said, because what came to me was not the words. What came was the transfer, and the room.

They moved her to an administrative post. That is the phrase. She kept her salary and her grade and her thirty years of service, and she was put in a room at the back of a building with no window in it, to check lists.

For six years.

And then she asked to go back to a classroom and they let her, without a word about any of it, as though the six years had been a thing she had chosen.

That is what her body kept, and it is the quietest thing in the book and I think it is one of the worst. **She does not finish sentences in front of people she does not know.** She starts them and then she does a thing with her hand, a small flick, and lets you finish it yourself. Everyone who knows her thinks it is a manner. It is not a manner. It is a woman who learned, in a room with no window, that an unfinished sentence cannot be reported.

She had told me the thing about the two verses with her eyes on the mirror and the dryer going two chairs away, in about ninety seconds, and then she had asked about the water.

I understand now what that cost and what it was. She was sixty-one years old and she had been moved twice and shut in a room for six years, and she looked at a girl of fifteen with her hands in a basin and decided to spend some of what she had left on telling her that a thing she had been raised to believe was settled was in fact an argument.

And her hair keeps it, in the dullest way imaginable. She has worn it short and practical since she was forty. Easy to do herself. Nothing anybody could comment on. Not one single feature of that woman's appearance has ever given anybody anything to write down.

I did not thank her. I did not say anything at all, ever, about any of it. She would have hated it, and more than that, it would have told her that someone had worked it out, and she had spent thirty years making sure nobody could.

16.

TO THE MIDDLE OF HER BACK AND SHE HAS NEVER CUT IT SHORTER THAN THAT.

Nothing. She wants it said that her husband is a good man, and he is.

I was stopped for the first time in Esfand, two weeks before the new year, on the pavement outside the fruit shop on our street, with a bag of oranges.

I was fifteen.

A woman in a chador and a man a little way behind her. The woman did the talking. She was not angry and she did not shout and she was not even unkind. She was about thirty-five and she sounded tired.

My scarf had gone back off my hairline, which happens, because it happens to everybody about forty times a day.

She said, sister, fix your scarf.

And I said sorry, and I fixed it.

And she said, God keep you, and they went on.

That is all of it. Eight seconds. I stood there with the oranges and my heart going like a bird, and then I went home and did not tell anybody.

I have gone over it since and the detail I keep arriving at is that she was working. She was out in Esfand, in the cold, on a Thursday, doing a shift. Somebody pays for that. **There is a line in a budget in this country for a woman to stand outside a fruit shop and ask a girl of fifteen to move four centimetres of cloth, and the water on our street goes off on Tuesdays.**

And here is the thing I need to put in, because it is the only part of it that is interesting.

It cost me nothing. Nothing at all. It is not in my book, because I am not in my book. If somebody had handed me an exercise book and told me to write down what my own head had cost me, I would have written **nothing**, and I would have been right.

But I was frightened for two days. I changed which way I walked to the bus for a month. I checked the mirror by the door in a way I had not before.

So it cost me something that does not go in a column.

The second time was in Farvardin, after the new year, and it was a man in a car who leaned over and said something out of the window and drove on, and it was not official in any way, and I have thought a great deal about why that one made me angrier.

I think it is because the woman in Esfand was doing a job. There was a thing she was for. I could see the shape of it. The man in the car was just a man in a car who had been told his whole life that my head was a matter he had standing in.

My aunt knew about the first one within a week. I do not know how. She did not ask me about it. What she did was start sending me on errands at different times of day, and she did it for about two months, and then she stopped, and she never once said why.

The woman at the basin that week had hair to the middle of her back and had never in her life cut it shorter. Her line says nothing. She wanted it put on the record — not my record, she did not know about my record, just said out loud to the room — that her husband was a good man and had never once in thirty-one years said one word to her about what she wore.

Several women in the room said, mine neither.

And one said nothing at all and looked at the floor, and I had washed her hair the month before, and I knew why.

17.

THIN AT THE LEFT TEMPLE. IT STILL HAS NOT CAUGHT UP.

Three hours in a van. And her husband's first question.

The woman in the green coat came back in Ordibehesht, a year and a month after the first time, and asked for me by name.

My aunt told me afterwards that she had been in twice in between and had sat in the chair for a cut and gone away without a wash both times, and had paid the full price both times and would not be talked out of it.

Her name was Hengameh. She was forty-four.

She sat down at the basin and she leaned straight back, no waiting, and she said: all right. Go on then.

And I washed her hair, and this time it came whole, and I am going to put it down the way I eventually got it, some of it from the water and some of it from her own mouth over the next two years, because she did tell me in the end. She is the only one who ever did.

It was years before I met her. She was in her thirties. She was coming out of a shop on a main road at about four in the afternoon with a plastic bag in her hand and there was a van at the kerb and two women and a man.

What she had on her head was a scarf. It was on her head. It was back off the hairline, the way mine was outside the fruit shop, the way everybody's is.

They asked for her identity card and she gave it to them, and then they said to get in.

She said, I remember asking if I could telephone my husband, and they said from the station, and I said what station, and nobody answered me, because there was no station. There was never a station. We drove around.

She was in that van for three hours.

And I need to say what she said next exactly, because she said it twice, a year apart, in the same words, which is how you know.

She said: nothing happened to me in the van.

She said: I want that understood. Nobody hit me. Nobody said anything filthy to me. There were four of us in the back by the end and the youngest one was crying and one of the women gave her a tissue out of her own bag.

She said: the only thing that happened is that when I would not get in, the man took hold of my hair at the side, here, through the scarf, and used it. Not hard. The way you move a chair.

Then they drove around for three hours and at some point she signed a paper that she did not read and was not given a copy of, and then at about seven in the evening they stopped the van and let her out.

On the same corner. The same one she had been picked up on. With her bag of shopping still in it.

She said: and that is the part nobody understands. They brought me back. Three hours of my life and then they put me down exactly where they found me, like a cat.

And then she went home.

And her husband was in the kitchen, and he had been telephoning her for three hours, and he turned round, and the first thing out of his mouth was:

What were you wearing?

18.

AND SHE HAS LET SOMEBODY ELSE DO IT NOW. FIRST TIME IN THIRTEEN YEARS.

Her marriage is fine. That is what she says and I believe her. It is just not the same marriage.

Here is what Hengameh's hair kept.

A patch at the left temple, about the size of a thumbprint, where the hair came back thinner and never caught up. Thirteen years. It is not bald and nobody would see it. It is thinner than the other side and it always will be, and she combs the front across it without thinking about it, the way you favour a knee.

And this, which is the real thing, and which I did not understand the size of until I was older.

She had not let another human being wash her hair in thirteen years.

Not a shop. Not her mother. Not her husband. She did it herself, at her own kitchen sink, with a jug, twice a week, for thirteen years, because the one thing she could not have was somebody standing behind her with their hands in her hair while she had her eyes shut and her neck back.

So when she came in the first time in that green coat, and stood just inside the door for too long, and sat forward with her hands in her lap and looked at the taps — that was a woman who had been working up to it, on and off, for thirteen years. And she came back twice and paid for a wash she did not have. And then she came back a third time and asked for me, and leaned straight back, and said go on then.

I was fifteen. I had no idea. I thought I was washing a nervous woman's hair.

And what her body kept is two things, and they are both small and neither of them is on any paper anywhere.

She cannot hear a diesel engine idling. Not a moving one. A stopped one. She will cross a street. She has crossed a street with me and said nothing about it and I said nothing either.

And she does not look at herself in the windows of parked cars. Everyone does that. Everyone in the world does that, a hundred times a week, without knowing. She does not. Her eyes go past it. I have watched her do it for years.

Now here is the arithmetic, and I did not do this arithmetic at fifteen. I did it much later, at the till, with the book open, going backwards through it.

What it cost her: a patch of her scalp, three hours, thirteen years of washing her own hair at a sink, two streets she cannot walk down, and the honest ground of her marriage. She says her marriage is fine, and I believe her, and she is right. It is a good marriage. It is just not the marriage it was at a quarter to seven that evening, because at seven o'clock she found out what the first thing he thought was.

And what it bought them — the van, the three hours, the paper she signed and never read:

She was out again, scarf back off her hairline, same as the rest of us, **within four months.**

She told me that herself and she laughed when she said it. She said: what were they expecting? I have one head.

19.

DOWN TO HER WAIST, AND SHE IS NINETEEN AND HAS NEVER HAD IT CUT.

Nothing. She wants to be a dentist and is worried about one subject.

That summer the radio said a number and the shop stopped.

A woman had been sentenced. The total was twenty-four years. And of the twenty-four, fifteen of them were for taking her scarf off in public.

Fifteen years.

I was sixteen and I did the thing you do, which is to count forward. I would be thirty-one. The girl at the basin that afternoon, who was nineteen and wanted to be a dentist, would be thirty-four. Khanom Ansari would be eighty-five and would almost certainly not be alive.

Nobody in that room said anything for a while. Then the woman under the dryer shouted what, and somebody told her, and she said God preserve us, and then — I remember this exactly — she said, well.

Well.

And that was the whole of the shop's response to fifteen years. One syllable, from a woman with her head under a dryer, who could not hear.

I was angry about that for a long time. I thought it was cowardice, or that it was the thing where people stop being able to feel a number after a while.

It was not either of those. I understand it now. **There was nothing to say.** There was no sentence available in that room that would have done anything at all. You cannot be sufficiently appalled. There is no quantity of appalled that reaches a courtroom; **it is not a currency they accept.** So you say *well*, and then you ask about the water on Tuesday, because the water on Tuesday is the only item on the agenda that anybody in that room has standing on.

But here is the part that matters, and it took me years to see it, and I only saw it because of the book.

Khanom Ansari lost twenty-two years of her life over a scarf she did not have with her, and the state did not have to spend anything to take it. No van. No file. No court. One man at a door, politely, and a letter that never came. **It cost them a morning's inconvenience and it bought them a ministry full of obedient women for years.**

And now they were spending fifteen years in a courtroom, in public, on paper, with a number that went around the world — and the girl at my basin, nineteen years old, who had heard the radio the same as the rest of us, came back six weeks later with her hair down to her waist and her scarf in her bag.

Not out of defiance. She did not make a speech. I asked her about it, actually, because I was sixteen and rude, and she said: oh, it's so hot, and I forget, and nobody says anything any more on our street.

Nobody says anything any more on our street.

They paid fifteen years in the most expensive, most public, most carefully recorded way they had ever paid for it.

And what they got for it was a nineteen-year-old on a bus with her scarf in her bag saying nobody says anything any more.

I did not have a word for what I was looking at. I was sixteen. The word I have for it now I got from my mother, and she got it from standing in a queue, and I will come to it.

20.

CUT TO THE JAW SIX WEEKS AGO. CUT TO THE JAW AGAIN TONIGHT.

Nothing came. Nothing ever comes. I have washed this head for two years.

My mother came off nights for one week in Tir and slept for three days and then on the fourth day she took me to buy shoes.

The shoes were a certain price. She looked at them and put them down and said something I have never forgotten, which is: last year this was the same number and it was a different shoe.

I said I did not understand.

And she said: the number did not change, Baran. The shoe got worse. That is how they do it. They do not tell you the money is worth less. They put less in the bag and leave the number on the front.

Everybody in this country knows that in their hands. You do not need to have been to school for it. You know it from bread. You know that the note in your pocket says what it said last year and will not buy what it bought last year, and that nobody announced that, and that nobody will ever announce it, and that there is no day on which it happened.

Hold on to that. It is the only idea in this book that is mine, and I got it in a shoe shop, which I think is where most of the good ones are.

That night I washed my aunt's hair, which I did every second week, and I wrote **nothing** on the second line the way I had written **nothing** on the second line about her for two years.

Earlier in the day she had cut her own hair, at the mirror, to the jaw. All one length. She had done it six weeks before and she did it that night and she would do it again in six weeks, and she had been doing it for as long as I had known her.

And afterwards she stood and looked at it with her head a little on one side, the way she always did, for about three seconds longer than a person looks at a haircut.

And then she said, right. And went and put the kettle on.

I had watched her do that, by then, something like twenty times.

I remember being mildly irritated that night, because I had wanted to try something with the front and she would not let me, and she was not even rude about it, she just said no, this length, and held up two fingers at her jaw, and that was the end of it.

I have gone back over that evening more times than any other evening in this book. There is nothing in it. We ate. She watched her serial. I did my homework at the kitchen table with the book in my bag and did not take it out.

She was fifty-two years old and she had already paid more than everybody else in my book put together, and I had my hands in her hair twice a month for five years and the water never told me one single thing about her, and I decided that this meant she had got off lightly.

21.

NOT WASHED. SHE CAME IN TO SIT DOWN.

A son, in Aban, and she does not know which hospital.

In Aban they put the price of fuel up overnight and the country came out into the road.

It was not about scarves. I want that in here, because everything in this book is about one thing and that week was not. It was about the price of fuel, and behind the price of fuel it was about the money, and behind the money it was about forty years, and there were men in it and boys in it and women in it and the whole street.

Then the internet went off.

Not slow. Off. For days. And when a country of that size has its internet turned off for days, what you have is a place where nobody can find out what is happening three streets away.

The shop did not open for three days. My aunt took the key with her and did not say anything about when.

And on the fourth day she opened it, and nobody came, and we sat in there with the radio on and the painted window and the licence in the frame and did not do one head all morning.

A woman came in at about two in the afternoon and did not want her hair washed. She sat down in the second chair with her coat on and asked for a glass of water.

She had a son. He had gone out on the second night and had not come back and it was now the fourth day and she did not know which hospital to go to, because when you do not know whether a person is in a hospital or somewhere else, every question you ask is also a piece of information about you.

She sat in that chair for about forty minutes. My aunt sat in the next one. Neither of them said very much. At one point my aunt held her hand, which I had never seen her do with a customer in two years.

I did not wash her hair. There is a line in my book for that day and the first column says **not washed, she came in to sit down**, which is the only time that appears, and the second column says what I have put at the top of this entry, and I wrote it from her face and her voice and not from the water, which means that by the standards of the rest of the book it should not be in there at all.

I left it in. It is still in. I decided at sixteen that it was going in and I have never changed my mind.

He was alive. I want to say that straight away because of what it is like to read it otherwise. He came home eight days later with his arm in a sling and a story about a friend's house that nobody in his family has ever contradicted and nobody in his family believes.

But I did not know that for eight days, and neither did she, and neither did my aunt, who sat in a chair holding the hand of a woman she had been doing hair for since before I was born.

And my aunt did not sleep that week, and asked me twice, in a voice she did not usually use, to come and sit in the front room while she watched the television.

I thought she was frightened for the street. I was sixteen. I thought it was about the street.

22.

TO THE SHOULDER. THE PARTING. SHE IS SEVENTY-TWO NOW.

And she asked me a question for once, and I lied to her.

Khanom Ansari came on the first Saturday of Azar with her money folded in her hand and the internet had been back for a week and nobody in the shop would talk about Aban at all.

That is a thing I should put down. There was no argument about Aban. There was no six opinions in six mouths. The money got argued about every week for four and a half years, and the dancing got argued about, and the sentence got a *well* out of a woman under a dryer.

Aban got nothing. The room went around it the way you go around a hole in a pavement, without looking down, for months.

I washed her hair. The parting was where it has always been. She was seventy-two.

And then with her eyes shut she said: how old are you now.

I said sixteen.

And she said: and what are you going to do.

I said I did not know. Which was true. I was sixteen and I liked chemistry and I was frightened of the examination the way everybody is frightened of the examination.

And she said: not that. I mean what are you going to do.

And I knew exactly what she meant, because she had told me about the hot pitch in my first week and she had told me about the man at the door and the letter that never came, and she was asking me whether I was going to spend my life the way she had spent hers, which is to say carefully.

And I said: I don't know, Khanom Ansari.

Which was a lie. I did know. What I knew was that I had a book in a drawer six feet from where she was lying with her neck in the porcelain, and that her twenty-two years were on page something-or-other of it in my handwriting, and that if anybody ever found that book I did not know what would happen but I knew it would not be nothing.

I had known that for about a year by then and I had not stopped writing it, and I had not asked my aunt why she wanted it, and I had not told one single person alive.

So the honest answer to what are you going to do was: I am already doing it, every day, at forty seconds a head, and I do not know what it is for.

I said I don't know, and she said hm, and I turned the water off, and I walked her up to the chair.

Four and a half years, and that is the only question she ever asked me.

23.

LONG, AND THE ENDS ARE WRECKED, AND SHE WILL NOT HAVE THEM OFF.

A business. Her brother's name on the lease and hers on nothing.

Towards the end of that year a man came round the shops on our street with a clipboard and a lanyard and went into four of them and not into ours.

My aunt watched him through the gap at the edge of the painted window for about twenty minutes. He went into the carpet place, the bakery, the shop that sells plastic, and the pharmacy. Not ours.

I have never seen my aunt so insulted by being left out of something she was frightened of.

She did not say anything to me about it that day. What she did was go round the shop in the evening after we had shut and check things. The frame on the wall, straight. The licence in date. The curtain on the rail, which she pulled all the way across and let go and pulled again. The gap at the edge of the paint where the brush had not quite reached the frame, which she went over with a fresh tin on the Friday, herself, standing on a chair, at fifty-two years old, with me holding the chair.

I said, Khaleh, it is one corner, nobody can see anything through it.

And she said: that is not the point.

I said, what is the point.

And she said: the point is that if a man comes in here with a clipboard I want there to be nothing at all for him to write down. Not one thing. Not a corner, not a date, not a cup in the sink.

I have thought about that sentence as much as any sentence in this book.

Because she painted over a corner of a window she had already painted, standing on a chair, at fifty-two, to stop a man writing down a true thing about a corner. **That is not fear of being punished. There was nothing to punish.** It is a different thing and I did not have a word for it then.

Because she was not frightened of being punished for something she had done. There was nothing to punish. The paint was fine and the licence was in date and the shop was clean.

She was frightened of being written down.

The woman at the basin that week had a business, a little one, printing on cloth, with four women working for her. The lease was in her brother's name. Everything was in her brother's name. She was the one who did all of it and she was on no piece of paper anywhere, on purpose, and had arranged her entire working life that way, and when I washed her hair what came was not an arrest or a fine or a van.

What came was **a woman who had made herself, carefully, over twenty years, into somebody with nothing in her own name.**

That is not a punishment. Nobody did it to her. There is no court anywhere that ordered it. It is what she worked out, by herself, from watching, and it has cost her her whole legal existence, and she will tell you it was simply the sensible thing.

Her ends were wrecked from a bad colour and she would not let my aunt take them off because she had been growing it since her mother died.

24.

TWO HUNDRED AND SIX HEADS SINCE DEY OF THE YEAR BEFORE LAST.

And eighty-one of them have something in the second column.

On the last night of Esfand I counted the book. Two hundred and six heads, and eighty-one of them with something in the second column.

Then I tried to add the second column up, and found out that you cannot. A morning and a van and three hours and twenty-two years and a room with no window are not the same kind of thing and there is no unit they all go into.

But I could see the shape of it, and the shape is what frightened me, and it is this.

Every single one of those eighty-one women paid it on her own.

Not one of them knew another one. I had them in a book, so I knew, which makes me the only person on earth who did know. Khanom Ansari did not know about Hengameh. Hengameh did not know about the teacher. The teacher did not know about the woman with the business in her brother's name, and that woman had been coming to that shop for six years and had sat in a chair next to at least four of the others and had talked to them about rice.

There was no one organising any of it. There was no list anywhere. Nobody had told any of them that what was being done to them was also being done to a hundred other women inside two kilometres of the same street. Each of them thought it was her own bad luck, or her own fault, or her own carelessness about a scarf on a hairline on an ordinary afternoon.

And on the other side there was no list either. The van was police. The morning was a man at a door in a ministry. The clipboard was from the municipality. The room with no window was the education office. Fifteen years was a court. A message is sent by something else again.

No two of them have to agree. No two of them ever did agree. **That is why the second-Thursday woman went fifty-nine years and was never touched once and Hengameh was put in a van for a scarf on a hairline, on the same street, in the same city, under the same rule.**

It is not a machine. I spent a year looking for the machine. **There is no machine.** There are a great many separate offices, each with its own paper, and none of them has ever added up what the others have taken, and there is no office anywhere whose job that is.

Which means the thing I had been imagining for a year — a room, a man, a list — does not exist, and I was almost disappointed, the way you are when you find out the person who has been ruining your life is not even thinking about you.

I was sixteen. I put the book back in my bag.

Then I went and stood in the doorway of the front room, where my aunt had fallen asleep in the chair with the serial on and the sound down, with her hair cut to the jaw, all one length, exactly the way it had been six weeks before and exactly the way it would be in another six.

And I did not know one single thing about her.

III. WHAT IT COST

There was a woman who had been a nurse in another country for twenty years and had come back to look after her father, and she had opinions about everything and no patience with any of us.

I asked her my question in the second year of the sickness, when we were all in masks and she was the only person in the shop who wore hers properly.

She said: you think this is a Muslim thing.

I said I had never said that.

She said: good, because it isn't, and I will tell you what I know and then you can go and find out the rest yourself, because nobody is going to hand it to you.

She said: the Greeks did it. The Romans did it. In the old Jewish law a married woman who went out with her head uncovered could be divorced and her husband did not have to pay her a thing. There is a letter in the Christian book telling women to cover their heads in church, and the reason it gives — she stopped here and laughed — the reason it gives is because of the angels. Go and look it up. Because of the angels.

She said: and all of those people were doing it before anybody in this part of the world had heard of our religion. It arrived into a place where it was already being done. It did not bring it.

And then she said the thing I did not expect from her, because she was not a sentimental woman.

She said: and do you know what is strange? If you look at the old pictures — the statues, the floors in the old houses, the ones with the little tiles — most of the women do not have anything on their heads. The priests were shouting about it for three hundred years and you look at the pictures and most of them are bare. And in the ones where a rich woman has a beautiful cloth on her head, the girl standing next to her holding the jug has nothing. The cloth was not modesty. The cloth was so you could tell which of them was the lady.

Then she washed her hands, although I was the one with my hands in the basin, and she said:

I will tell you why it is always hair, and then I am going to stop talking about it, because it upsets me.

She said: I worked for twenty years in a ward. When somebody is going, you cut a piece of their hair and you put it in an envelope and you write the name on the front and you give it to the family. I have done it hundreds of times. Nobody asks you to and everybody wants it.

She said: now think about why it is the hair and not anything else.

She said: because it is the only part of a person you can take off them and hand to somebody else, and it does not hurt them, and it is still them. That is all. That is the whole reason, and it is four thousand years old, and it is why it ended up in a law.

Then she said, is that hot enough, and I said yes, and she did not say another word about any of it for the rest of the time I knew her.

25.

**TO THE SHOULDER. SHE ASKED FOR IT SHORTER THAN USUAL,
IN CASE.**

Nothing. Her sister-in-law is a nurse and will not come to the house.

In Farvardin of the next year they shut everything, and the shop was shut for most of three months.

The last Wednesday before we shut, a woman came in and asked for it shorter than she liked it, in case, and that is the only thing anybody said out loud all day about what was coming. In case.

Then the shutters came down and stayed down.

I want to put in what that did to the book, because it is the only thing that happened to the book that I did not do myself.

There is a page in the middle of it with a date at the top and then nothing underneath, and then the next date is most of three months later. A gap. The only gap in five years.

And when we opened again, every single head that came through that door was wrong.

Long. All of them. Grown out, every colour gone two or three centimetres up from the root, cuts that had been cut in winter sitting on women in summer, grey everywhere — grey on women I had never once seen with grey, because they had been coming to that shop every four weeks for twenty years and I had genuinely never seen them.

My aunt stood in the middle of the shop on the first morning, looked at the four of them waiting, and said: God. Look at us.

They had shut the shops, the schools, the offices and the shrines, in that order, and the shrines went last and went hardest, and in the middle of it somebody somewhere was still having to decide whether a hairdresser counts. **I would pay money to read that file.**

And a woman in the second chair said: this is what we actually look like.

Everybody laughed. It was funny. It was also the truest thing said in that shop in five years and I wrote it down on a separate piece of paper and kept it in the back of the book, which I had never done before.

This is what we actually look like.

The first column of my book for that month is useless. Useless. I had been measuring something for two years and then the thing I was measuring was suspended for most of three months and came back unrecognisable, and the only reason was that the shops were shut.

If anybody had ever looked at my book to find out something about the women of that district, the gap would have told them nothing except that there was a sickness.

But it told me something, and it is the first thing I understood on my own without anybody saying it to me.

The first column was never about the women. It was about the shop. It was a record of a service. Who got in, how often, and what the trade could do for them.

The second column was the only part of that book that was about the women themselves.

26.

GREY ALL ALONG THE PARTING AND SHE IS LEAVING IT NOW.

Nothing. A fine for the shop, which was not about this, and which she paid in a morning.

Then for about a year and a half everybody in the country covered their face.

I was seventeen and I want to be careful here, because I have heard people say clever things about this and most of them are too clever.

It was not the same. A mask is not a scarf. Nobody was ever put in a van for a mask. The reason for a mask was a sickness, and the sickness was real, and I had a great-aunt who died of it in Ramadan and we could not go.

But something happened in that shop that I still think about.

The radio told us to cover our faces. There were signs on the bus and the bank and the bakery. There were men at doors not letting people in. For a year and a half, the whole machinery of this country — the radio, the signs, the men at the doors, the fines — was pointed at getting everybody to put a thing over the middle of their face.

And a lot of people did not do it. They wore it under the chin. They wore it on the wrist. They pulled it up when they went past a man at a door and pulled it down afterwards.

And I stood at the basin and watched a room full of women who had spent their entire lives pulling a scarf forward when they went past a man at a door, and pulling it back afterwards, do exactly the same thing with a mask, with exactly the same hand, in exactly the same movement.

They were extremely good at it. **They had forty years of practice.**

So the one thing this country has successfully taught every woman in it, at enormous expense, over four decades, is **how to appear to comply**. That is the national competence. We are world-class. If there were a competition we would send a team.

The second-Thursday woman said something that week that was the most intelligent thing she ever said in that shop, and she said it while complaining, which is how most intelligent things get said.

She said: they have taught us to do this. Forty years of making us cover something has taught every woman in this country how to look like she is obeying and not obey.

And then she said she still was not wearing it on the bus because it made her glasses go.

Nobody won that argument either. The woman in the next chair said the sickness was a lie and her cousin was a pharmacist. The teacher, who was in that morning, said nothing and did the thing with her hand.

That was the year I started to see the second column differently, and it was because of the masks and because of my mother's shoe.

Here is what I had. Khanom Ansari had lost twenty-two years to one morning and one piece of cloth, and it had cost the state one polite man at a door. Hengameh had lost thirteen years of letting anybody near her head, and it had cost them a van and an afternoon and four men's wages. Fifteen years in a courtroom had bought them a nineteen-year-old with her scarf in her bag.

The price they were paying was going up. And what they were getting for it was going down.

I did not have the word. My mother had the word, from the shoe shop, and I was still a year away from putting the two together.

27.

SHORT, GREY, AND SHE HAS NEVER DYED IT AND NEVER WILL.

Nothing of her own. She is carrying her sister's, and it does not go in a column.

The nurse came in on a Thursday at the end of that summer with her father's prescriptions in her bag, sat down, and said, you again.

She had worked abroad for twenty years and she could not stop comparing, and she knew she should stop, and she did not. Somebody once asked her how she found things since she came back and she thought about it and said, warmer.

She had been in four or five times by then. She was sixty and she had been away for twenty years and had come back, and she had the thing people have when they have lived somewhere else, which is that she could not stop comparing and knew she should stop and did not.

That was the Thursday she told me about the Greeks and the Romans and the law about a married woman's head, and the letter about the angels, and the pictures where the rich woman has the cloth and the girl with the jug has nothing.

And then she told me about the envelopes.

She said she had cut hair off people in a ward hundreds of times and put it in an envelope and written the name on the front and given it to a family, and that nobody had ever asked her to do it and everybody had wanted it.

And then she said: that is why it is always hair. It is the only part of a person you can take off them and hand to somebody else, and it does not hurt them, and it is still them.

I stood there with the water running and I understood about four things at once, and I am going to try to put them down in the order they arrived, because it is the only time in this whole book that I worked something out instead of being handed it.

The first was that she was right and that it was obvious and that nobody had ever said it to me.

The second was that this is why it is in the law. Not because it is beautiful and not because men are weak. Because it is the one piece of a person that works as a sign. You can put a cloth over it. You can take it away. You can measure it, which is what I had been doing for two and a half years. **It is the part of a body that behaves like a thing.**

The third was that this is why I could read it. I did not say that out loud and I have never said it out loud. But a head of hair grows about a centimetre a month and it does not throw anything away, and I had a drawer full of pages proving that it keeps a record, and the nurse had just told me, without knowing what she was telling me, why it would be hair and not an elbow.

And the fourth one came later that night and it is the one that frightened me.

If it is the part of a body that behaves like a thing, then a rule about it is not a rule about a body. It is a rule about property.

Khanom Ansari had said that to me in my first week. She had said: it was not a wall, it was a label. She had said: so a man in the road could tell whose you were.

I had written it down at fourteen and carried it for three years and not understood one word of it.

What came off the nurse in the water, by the way, was nothing of her own. She had never been stopped in her life; she had been out of the country for most of the years when it would have happened. What she was carrying was her sister's, who had not left, and who she will not discuss, and whose hair she does herself at the kitchen table every six weeks because her sister will not come into a shop.

28.

LONG, DYED DARK, ROOTS DONE EVERY SIX WEEKS WITHOUT FAIL.

I have been doing this head since I was fourteen and I have never asked what I am covering.

Shaghayegh came every six weeks on a Tuesday and had done since before I started, and I did her colour, and had done since I was fifteen, which was the first colour my aunt ever let me do on my own.

She was twenty-five. She worked in an office that did something with freight. She had a laugh that made the whole shop turn round.

And her hair was dyed dark, all over, every six weeks, without one single missed appointment in four years. Not a week late. Not once. My aunt used to say she could set the calendar by her.

I did the roots. You do the parting first, then you section, then you work out from the crown. I had my hands on that scalp for forty minutes every six weeks for four years.

And here is the thing that I think about more than almost anything else in this book.

I never once asked what I was covering.

The front of her hairline was white. Not grey — white, and only at the front, in a band about four fingers wide, and underneath and behind it she was dark the way a twenty-five-year-old is dark.

I had known that about her for four years the way you know the pattern on your own kitchen floor. I had mixed the colour for it. I had learned to take it right to the skin at the front because that was the bit that showed first. We had a joke about it. She used to say, mind the stripe. **I want it on the record that for four years I thought I was the one making her laugh.**

Mind the stripe.

That was the joke, for four years, between a girl of fifteen and a woman of twenty-one who went white at the front in one season at the age of twenty-one, and who came back every six weeks for the rest of her life so that nobody would ask her about it, and who paid me to put the brush right up to the skin.

And nothing ever came off her in the water. Not for four years.

I have thought hard about why and I think I know, and it is not mystical and I am not going to pretend it is. I did not wash Shaghayegh's hair. I coloured it. Colour is dry hair, gloves, a brush, a bowl, a timer. My hands were never in the water on her head, not once in four years, because the rinse at the end is done by whoever is free and it was usually my aunt.

Four years. Six weeks apart. Thirty-four times, or something near it. And the one week in Dey when my aunt had flu and I did the rinse as well as the colour was the week I found out.

29.

THE SAME AS ALWAYS. AND I DID THE RINSE MYSELF.

Nothing happened to her. They took her sister.

My aunt had flu in Dey and I ran the shop with a woman she brought in for the week, and on the Tuesday Shaghayegh came for her roots and I did the whole thing, the colour and the timer and then the rinse.

I tipped her back and put my hand under the back of her head to lift it off the porcelain.

Nothing happened to her. They took her sister.

Her sister is three years older. I am not going to write what she was taken for because I do not actually know — I know what came into me and what came into me was not the charge, it was the four years.

Because it was four years.

Shaghayegh was twenty-one. And for four years she did the following things, every week, on top of having a job.

She went to the place you go. She queued. She found out which window, and then the window changed, and she found out again. She learned which days you could bring food and what you were allowed to bring and the exact size the bag had to be. She learned the name of a man who would take the bag in if you were late and what you gave him.

She found the money. All of it. Her family had some and then they did not have some. She sold a gold bangle that was her grandmother's and she did not tell her mother for a year.

She found a lawyer, then a second lawyer, because the first one took the money and did not do anything, which she says happens and which she says you cannot complain about to anybody.

She put up a property. Not hers — there was nothing of hers. She stood in an office and watched her parents sign a paper against the flat they lived in, so that her sister could be out for a certain number of months, and she was the one who had arranged it and she was the one who had to sit in the room while it happened.

And she took the telephone calls. Six in the morning, mostly, because that is when they come. Four years of a telephone going at six in the morning in a flat with four people in it.

And she went every single time. Every visit. Four years.

Her sister served the sentence.

And Shaghayegh served the sentence.

Nobody wrote her name down anywhere in any of it. She has no file. She was not charged with anything and not convicted of anything and not sentenced to anything. If you went to every office in this city and asked what it cost to hold her sister for four years, every single answer you got would be about her sister.

I finished the rinse. I towelled her and sat her up and she looked at me in the mirror and said, mind the stripe, and I said, I know, and she laughed, and I went into the back and put both hands flat on the wall.

30.

WHITE AT THE FRONT ONLY, AND IT CAME IN ONE SEASON.

It fell out in the week her sister came home.

Here is what Shaghayegh's hair kept, and I did not get this from the water. I got it from the water and then I went and checked it against the thing I already knew about hair, and the two of them fitted, and it is the worst arithmetic in this book.

A third of her hair fell out.

Not all at once in the way people mean when they say that. Over about six weeks. In the shower, on the pillow, in the brush, in handfuls.

And it did not happen when her sister was taken.

It happened **three months after**.

I need to say why that matters, in the plainest words I have, because when I worked it out I had to sit down on the step in the yard in the cold.

Hair does not come out when the thing happens. It cannot. What happens when something goes through you is that the hair on your head stops growing and sits there. It just stops. And it stays on your head, looking exactly like hair, for about three months. And then it lets go.

So everybody's hair tells you what happened to them three months ago. Everybody's. Yours. Mine.

Which means that for every woman in that book, the worst week of her life and the week her hair came out are two different weeks, and the second one is always the quiet one. The one where it is over. The one where nobody is bringing food any more and nobody is telephoning and everybody has gone back to work and you are supposed to be relieved.

Shaghayegh's hair came out in the week her sister came home.

Four years of queues and bags and six o'clock telephone calls and a bangle and her parents' flat, and she got through all of it with her hair on her head, and then her sister walked in the door, and there was a party, actually, a small one, with the family, and Shaghayegh made the rice.

And three weeks later she was pulling it out of the plughole with a fork.

It came back white at the front. Only at the front, only in that band, and it has stayed white, and she will be white at the front at sixty.

And what her body kept is one thing and it is very small.

She cannot make a telephone call.

She can answer one. She can talk on one for an hour. She cannot place one. She cannot press the numbers and hold it and wait for somebody to pick up. Four years of six in the morning did that, and it did not go away when the four years ended, and it has not gone away since.

So when there is a call to make — the dentist, the office, the man about the boiler — she hands the telephone to her sister, and her sister makes it.

Her sister, who did the four years inside.

Her sister is completely fine on a telephone.

And that is the only place in this entire book where I am going to put down a thing I worked out myself, in my own words, and it is this.

You cannot make a house afraid twice.

They took one woman out of that flat and they got four years of her life. And what they spent to do it was spent on a family where nobody — not the mother, not the father, not Shaghayegh, not her sister — covers anything any more. Not out of politics. They just stopped. It fell off them. They had already had the worst of it and there was nothing left to hold over them, and they knew it, and I think the people who do this know it too and have no way of saying so to each other.

31.

MINE.

Nothing. Nothing at all. I tried three times.

I washed my own hair at the basin after we shut, in Esfand, alone, with the shutters down and one light on at the back.

I had been working up to it for a month and I had not admitted to myself that this was what I was doing.

It is not easy to do. The basin is made for somebody else's head. I had to kneel on the floor and get my neck into the dip sideways and run the water with one hand, and I did it properly, both hands in it, the way I do it on a customer, flat palm under the back of the head.

And nothing came.

I did it again two days later, and nothing came.

I did it a third time in Farvardin and knelt there on the wet tiles with the water running over my wrist for much longer than you should, and nothing came, and I sat back against the cupboard with my hair in my face and understood that there was nothing to come.

I had not been stopped except for eight seconds outside a fruit shop with a bag of oranges. I have never been in a van. I have never signed anything. Nobody has ever telephoned my father, who is not in this and never has been. My name is in no office. I have never lost a day's work or a day's school or a single thing I wanted.

My column is empty.

I was seventeen years old and I had two hundred and ninety-odd heads in a book and eighty of them had something in the second column, and I had the only copy, and I was the only person in it who had paid nothing.

I would like to be able to write that I was relieved. I have read that sentence back a number of times and it is the only place in this book where I have tried to make myself sound better than I was.

What I actually felt, kneeling on those tiles, was something I did not have a word for until much later and which I am fairly sure was shame. Not guilt. Guilt is for something you did. I had not done anything. It was the other thing, the one where you look at what you have got and you understand that somebody bought it and that it was not you.

Because here is what I could see, and I could only see it because of the book, which nobody else had.

I walk down a street at seventeen with my scarf halfway back off my head, and when a shopkeeper's son looks at me it is just a boy looking at a girl and not a matter anybody has standing in. And the reason for that is not that the rule changed. The rule did not change. The rule is exactly where it was.

The reason is Khanom Ansari's twenty-two years, and Hengameh's three hours and her thirteen years at a kitchen sink, and the teacher's six years in a room with no window, and Shaghayegh's four years of six o'clock telephone calls, and two hundred-odd more whose names are not in my book because I never wrote the names down.

Every one of them paid on her own. None of them knew any of the others. Nobody thanked a single one of them, and nobody is going to, and there is no office that would even know how to accept the thanks.

And I got the street.

I put the book in my bag and I mopped the floor and I locked the back and I went home and my aunt had left me food.

32.

TO THE SHOULDER. THE PARTING. SHE IS SEVENTY-FOUR.

The same morning. It is always the same morning.

Khanom Ansari came on the first Saturday of Ordibehesht and I said something to her that I had been carrying for three years.

I said: Khanom Ansari, in my first week you told me about the old law. The one where the wife covered and the woman who was owned was forbidden to.

And she said: did I.

And I said yes. And you said it was not a wall, it was a label.

She did not open her eyes. She said: well. It is.

And I said: I think I have only just understood it.

And she said: go on, then.

So I told her, with my hands in her hair, and it came out badly because I had never said it out loud.

I said: if the covering was to keep women safe from men, then the first woman you would cover is the one with nobody. The one anybody can do anything to. The slave. The one in the street at night.

And instead the law said she was forbidden. On pain of being burned.

So it was never for her. It was never about keeping anybody safe at all. It was a sign you put on a woman so that a stranger could tell what kind she was and whose she was, and that is a thing you do to property, and the only reason it is always hair is that hair is the part of a person that behaves like a thing — you can put a cloth over it, you can take it off, you can measure it.

And then I said the part I had not planned to say.

I said: which is why nobody can answer me. For three years. Not one person. Not because they are lying. Because there is nothing there to say. It is not a reason that came out badly. **There was never a reason in it at all. There is only a thing nobody will say.**

And Khanom Ansari, who was seventy-four years old and had been sent home at ten in the morning over a piece of cloth and never let back in, lay there with her eyes shut and her neck in the porcelain, and said:

Yes.

That is all she said. Yes. One word, and then she asked whether the water was going cold, which was the thing she always asked and which I understood by then was how she ended a subject.

And I did the second wash and towelled her and walked her up to the chair.

And the thing I had said a hundred times — *then it is the men* — did not come out of my mouth that day, and I noticed it had not, and it did not come out of my mouth again for a long time afterwards.

Not because it was wrong. It was not wrong. It is still not wrong.

It had just become a very small thing to say about what I was looking at. **It was a joke about a man on a bus, and I was holding a bill.** It was an argument, and I had been having it for three years with people who were not the ones holding the other end of it, in a room with a painted window, while the actual arrangement sat four thousand years underneath and did not need an argument because it had never had a reason.

33.

CAME IN WITH NOTHING ON HER HEAD.

Nothing. She is twenty-two and she walked from the bus like that.

In Tir of that year a woman walked into the shop with nothing on her head.

I want to put that down slowly because of how long I had been waiting for it without knowing that I was.

She came in off the street at about four in the afternoon. She pushed the door and the bell went and she came in and stood at the counter and asked whether anybody could do her a trim.

And her head was bare. There was no scarf pushed back. There was no scarf round her shoulders. There was no scarf in her hand. I looked at her hands.

She was twenty-two. She had walked from the bus stop on the main road, which is about four hundred metres, past the fruit shop and the pharmacy and the two shops with clipboards and the bakery.

My aunt came out of the back and stopped.

And then she said, of course, sit down, Baran will take you.

Nobody said anything about it. Not one word, from anybody, the whole time she was in that shop. There were four other women in there and all four of them had taken their scarves off at the door the way you do, and not one of them said anything, and the thing in that room for about twenty minutes was so loud I could hear it over the dryer.

I washed her hair and nothing came off her at all. Nothing. Twenty-two years old and never stopped once in her life.

And I asked her — I had to, I was seventeen — I said, you walked here like that?

And she said: from the bus.

And I said: and nobody said anything?

And she said, and I have this exactly, because I wrote it on the loose paper at the back of the book that evening:

Not on our street. Not for a while now. You should try it.

Not on our street. Not for a while now.

She was not being brave. She was not making a point. She did not know she was doing anything at all. She had worked out, from walking about, that on those particular four hundred metres, at that particular time of day, nothing would happen — and she was right, and nothing did.

That is the first entry in my book with nothing in the first column.

Came in with nothing on her head.

And I sat at the till and looked at those words for a while, because the first column was supposed to be a measurement. It was supposed to be the thing you could see from the pavement and the thing the window was painted over for. And here was a head that had already been seen from the pavement, by a hundred people, for four hundred metres, before it ever got to me.

What exactly was I measuring?

I did not understand what was happening to my own book yet. I thought it was one woman.

By the end of that year it was fourteen of them.

34.

TO THE WAIST, AND A MESSAGE CAME TO HER HUSBAND ABOUT IT.

A photograph she never saw, taken somewhere she cannot name, by something she cannot point at.

That autumn the second column started to change and I changed with it.

Up until then, everything in it had a place and a person. A van. A door. A courtroom. A room with no window. An office with a clipboard. You could point at the thing that had done it, even if you could not do anything about it.

And then I started getting these.

A woman came in in Aban with hair to her waist and what came off her was a photograph. Not one she had been shown. Not one that was taken by anybody standing in front of her. She had been somewhere — a street, a square, she does not know which — and something had taken her picture, and some days later a message arrived on a telephone.

Not hers. **Her husband's.**

It had her name in it and the place and the day.

She never saw the photograph. She does not know what she looked like in it. She does not know who has it or where it is or whether it is still anywhere. There is no office she could go to and ask, because asking is the same as telling them you want to know, and she does not know which office to ask anyway.

And what it cost her is not a day or a fine or a year. It is that there is now a thing with her name on it, in a place she cannot locate, which somebody can look at, and she will not find out about it until it is used.

Her hair keeps nothing. There is nothing in it. That is what I had to write and it is why I started writing the second column smaller.

Because this is where the arithmetic I had been doing stopped working.

The van cost them four men's wages and an afternoon, and it bought them four months of Hengameh.

Fifteen years in a courtroom cost them a public record and a number the whole world repeated, and it bought them a nineteen-year-old with her scarf in her bag.

A photograph taken by nobody and a message sent to a husband costs them **almost nothing**. No wages. No van. Nobody has to stand on a pavement in the cold. One man at a desk somewhere, who has never met her, who presses a thing.

So I thought: that is clever. That is them getting cheaper. That must be better for them.

And it is not. That is the part that took me another year.

Because she was back on the street inside a week. Of course she was. Nothing had happened to her. Nothing had been done to her body. She had not lost a day.

What she had lost was her husband's peace, and he is now the one who checks the telephone.

They have moved it. The whole thing has moved off her and onto him. He is a perfectly ordinary man who sells plumbing fittings and he has not been accused of anything, and he now looks at a screen every evening, and that is where the rule lives in that house now.

I wrote it small. Not to hide it. Because my hand had started doing a thing by then.

35.

CUT TO THE JAW, ALL ONE LENGTH, AS ALWAYS.

Nothing. Five years and nothing.

My aunt took me to a dentist in Azar because of my jaw.

I had started doing a thing in my sleep, and in the day as well, and I did not know I was doing it. She knew. She had been watching it for a year. She said it in the way she said everything, which was while doing something else.

She said: you are grinding your teeth. There is a man on the main road. We are going on Thursday.

The dentist was about forty and perfectly nice and he looked in my mouth for a while and he said the back two on the left were going flat and he could make me a thing to wear at night and I should try to be less worried about the examination.

That is what he decided it was. The examination. Which was reasonable — I was seventeen and three-quarters, everybody my age was being destroyed by the examination, and he must have had four of us a week. **It is the first time in my life I was glad of it. For about a year the examination covered for me the way a cousin covers for you.**

In the car afterwards my aunt said: is it the examination.

And I said yes.

And she looked at the road for a while and then she said: all right.

She knew it was not the examination. I know she knew because of the way she said all right — not the way you say it when you believe somebody, the way you say it when you have decided not to make them lie twice.

And I was not going to tell her, for the same reason I had not told her for three years, which is that she had burned eighteen years of names in a barrel in a yard and I had worked out by then that you do not hand a thing like this to a person like that.

So we drove home and she bought me a cake on the corner like I was nine.

That was the same week I noticed what my own handwriting had been doing.

I had gone back through the book looking for something and I got to the pages from about the middle of the second year and I saw it.

The first column is the same all the way through. It firms up over the five years the way anybody's does between fourteen and nineteen, but it is the same hand, the same size, the same slope.

The second column gets smaller.

It starts the same size as the first. By the middle of the second year it is noticeably smaller. By that autumn it is tiny — cramped, down in the corner of the line, in letters about half the height.

And I did not decide to do that. Not once. There was no day where I thought I will write this part smaller. My hand did it on its own over three years, forty seconds at a time, at a till, with a dryer going.

I sat in the shop that night with the book open at two pages, one from the first month and one from that week, and I looked at them side by side.

And the only thing I could think, and I am not going to dress it up, was: so this is what it looks like from the outside. This is what it looks like when it is in a person's hand instead of in her body.

I washed my aunt's hair that evening and nothing came, as it never did, and she cut it herself to the jaw at the mirror, all one length, as she always did, and stood and looked at it for three seconds too long, and said right, and went and put the kettle on.

36.

THREE HUNDRED AND FORTY-ONE HEADS. FOURTEEN OF THEM CAME IN BARE.

A hundred and nine in the second column, and I cannot add it up, and I have stopped trying.

On the last night of Esfand I counted it again, the way I had two years before, at the kitchen table with the serial on in the front room.

Three hundred and forty-one heads.

A hundred and nine with something in the second column.

And fourteen that came in off the street with nothing on their heads at all. Fourteen, in one year, where the year before there had been none in four.

I put the three numbers on the loose paper at the back and then I sat there and I finally put the two things together, and it took about a minute, and once it was done it could not be undone.

My mother in the shoe shop: *the number did not change. The shoe got worse.*

And my book.

Here is what my book says, and it is the only thing in it that nobody told me and nobody could have.

They have never lowered the price.

They are still paying it. A van still costs a van. A court still costs a court. A man at a door still costs a man at a door. Nobody in any office in this country has reduced what they are willing to spend on a woman's head — if anything they have found new ways to spend, the photograph and the message and the thing that sends it.

And what they get for it goes down every single year.

Twenty-two years of Khanom Ansari's life, in exchange for one morning's work by a polite man at a door — and a whole building full of women who did not put a foot wrong for a decade.

A van and an afternoon and four wages — and four months of Hengameh.

Fifteen years, read out in a court, in public, in a number the whole world said out loud — and a nineteen-year-old on a bus saying nobody says anything any more on our street.

A photograph taken by nothing and a message sent to a husband — and she was back out in a week and now he is the one who cannot sleep.

The same money. Less and less in the bag.

And nobody did that to them. Nobody organised it, nobody declared it, there is no committee anywhere that voted for it. **They did it to themselves, one woman at a time, for forty years.** Nobody in the entire arrangement has ever had to sit in a room and be told that this is what the money was going on. Every single woman they took and did not break made the next woman slightly less afraid, and the two of them never met, and never spoke, and will never know the other one existed, and that is why there is nobody to arrest for it.

That is in a school exercise book with a cardboard cover, in a drawer under a till, in a shop with a painted window, in the handwriting of a girl of eighteen, and it is written nowhere else on earth.

I did not know what to do with it. I want to be honest: I did not think of it as dangerous. I thought of it as *mine*, which is a stupid thing to think about a book with three hundred other people's lives in it, and which I only stopped thinking in Mehr of the following year, when a man came into the shop with a folder and asked my aunt, very politely, for her appointment books.

IV. THE RECKONING

The man with the folder told me this on his second visit, and he was not trying to help me. It was the material of his job and he was passing the time while my aunt looked for something.

He said: people think we are the only ones.

He said it almost kindly. He had a bad back and he kept shifting in the chair.

He said: we are not the only ones. In the country next door it is the law too, and it is harder than ours. There was an order a few years ago that women should wear the full covering. And here is the part nobody here knows — in their law the punishment does not fall on the woman. It falls on her father, or her nearest male relative. They go to him. He is visited. He can lose his post. He can be put inside.

He said: and then a few years after that they put out a whole law, article by article, and one of the articles says a woman is required to cover her entire body, and that she should cover her face, and — he looked at the ceiling to get it right — and that a woman's voice is also something that should be concealed.

He said: her voice.

Then he said: in one province of a country far away from here, in the east, there is a provincial law, and they have men who patrol for it, and they put the cane on people.

And he said: and in one country in Africa it was the law for thirty years and then it was not.

I said: what happened?

And he said: they stopped describing themselves that way.

Then he looked at his hands and said something that I have turned over ever since, because I do not think he meant anything by it at all.

He said: it is a short list. For something that is supposed to be the natural order of things, it is a very short list.

And I said: it is getting shorter.

And he said yes, without any particular feeling, the way you agree about the weather.

And I said: and nobody who took their name off that list ever stood up and said so, did they.

And he thought about it, properly, for a few seconds, like a man checking a figure.

And then he said: no. I suppose they didn't.

And my aunt came back with the thing he had asked for, and he put his pen on it, and that was the end of the only conversation about any of this that I ever had with anybody from that side of it in my life.

37.

**CAME IN WITH NOTHING ON HER HEAD. SO DID THE NEXT ONE.
SO DID THE ONE AFTER THAT.**

Nothing. Nothing. Nothing.

By Farvardin I had stopped being able to use the first column.

It had taken about a year and it had happened without one single announcement, which I had learned by then is how everything in this country happens.

Three in a row, one Tuesday morning. Then four out of six on a Thursday. Then a week where I wrote **came in with nothing on her head** so many times that I started just writing **bare** and then stopped writing anything at all, because what exactly was I recording?

The first column was supposed to be the thing you could not see from the street. That was the whole point of it. That was what the paint on the window was for. I had spent four years writing down a private fact, and the private fact had walked out of the shop and onto the pavement and gone to the bakery.

So the first column died.

It did not die because I gave up on it. It died because it was a measurement of a secret and the secret was over. There is a stretch of about thirty pages near the end of that book where the first line is almost nothing — *bare, bare, bare, scarf round her shoulders, bare* — and the second line goes on and on.

And that is the thing I want somebody to notice if anybody ever reads it.

The street got freer and the bill kept arriving.

Every week, still. A fine. A business. A message to a husband. A nephew. A place at a university. The second column did not slow down at all. If anything there was more in it, because by then they had the cheap methods and the cheap methods can be used on everybody.

So anybody looking at that book from the outside, in one of the two ways people look at this country, would be wrong.

If you only read the first column you would say: look, it is over, they have won, the women are bare-headed on the street, what is everybody complaining about.

And if you only read the second column you would say: nothing has changed at all, it is exactly what it was.

And both of those are in the same book, on the same page, in two lines, in the same handwriting, and they are both true, and I did not do that on purpose. I wrote down what was there, which is the only instruction I was ever given.

38.

BARE. SEVENTEEN. GOOD HAIR, NEVER COLOURED, NEVER CUT SHORTER THAN THIS.

Nothing in it. Nothing at all. I went back twice.

A girl of seventeen came in on a Wednesday in Ordibehesht with her mother, who wanted a colour, and she was seventeen and she sat and waited and then said she might as well have a wash while she was there.

She had come from school. She had her bag. She was bare-headed and so was her mother and neither of them had a scarf anywhere about them that I could see.

I washed her hair and nothing came.

That is not unusual. A hundred and whatever pages of that book say nothing. But I had got to the point where I could tell the difference between a head with nothing in it and a head with nothing in it *yet*, and this was neither. There was something wrong with it. It was like putting your hand into a drawer you know has a thing in it and finding the drawer empty.

So I did something I had never done. I went back in. I did a second wash she had not asked for, and then at the end I did the rinse myself when I did not need to, which gave me a third go, and I kept my hand flat on the back of her head for longer than you should.

Nothing. Nothing. Nothing.

And then at the chair, while my aunt was doing her mother, she told the whole shop about it herself, in about ninety seconds, laughing, in the voice girls that age use for things that are not funny.

She said: oh, I got stopped in Esfand.

Somebody asked what happened.

She said: nothing happened. They took my name. A woman took a photograph of me on a telephone. I was there about four minutes. Then I got a message and that was that.

And her mother said, from the chair, without turning round: tell her about your father.

And she said: oh. Yeah. They sent one to my dad as well.

And that is the whole of it. Four minutes on a pavement in Esfand, a photograph on a telephone, a message to her, a message to him.

She was back out the next morning with her head bare, and she did not think of herself as having done anything, and she was right, because by then on that street she had not done anything.

I sat at the till with the book open for a long time that afternoon.

Because by then I could do the arithmetic in my head the way you do multiplication, and hers came out at the bottom of it.

Four minutes. One photograph. Two messages. **It is the cheapest thing they have ever done to anybody in my book**, by a distance, and the whole of what it bought them was **one night**. She was out again before the shop opened.

The first column of her entry says bare. The second column of her entry says nothing at all.

And it is a lie, and it took me a month to find out why.

39.

**HER MOTHER'S. A COLOUR, AND SHE TALKED THE WHOLE TIME,
AND I DID THE RINSE.**

Her husband has not spoken a full sentence to his daughter in a year.

her mother came back for her roots a month later, and this time I did the rinse, and I found out where her entry had gone.

It had gone to her father.

It is in his house. It is not in her head at all.

Here is what came, and I am going to put it down flat because it is the quietest thing in this book and I think it is the thing I understand least and like least.

He is a man of about fifty. He has a shop that sells fittings for plumbers — brass things, in drawers, with the sizes written on the drawers in marker.

He got a message on a Thursday in Esfand. It had his daughter's name in it and the name of a street and a date.

That is all that has ever happened to him. Nobody has visited him. Nobody has telephoned him. Nothing has been done to his shop. He has not been accused of one single thing.

And he has not spoken a full sentence to his daughter in a year.

He is not angry with her. That is the part his wife said out loud at the mirror, to my aunt, in the ordinary voice you use for a family problem. She said: he is not angry with her. He asks about her at dinner, to me, with her sitting there.

He answers the door himself now. He did not use to. If somebody knocks, he goes.

He looks at his telephone in the evening. Not scrolling — looking. His wife said he picks it up and looks at it and puts it down and does it again twenty minutes later, every evening, for a year.

Because the first message was the first message. And nobody has ever told him whether there is a second one. There is no office he can ring and ask. If he went anywhere and asked, the asking would be the thing that put him on a list, and he is a man who sells brass fittings and he knows that much.

So he waits. He has been waiting for a year. He will probably wait for the rest of his life, and nothing will come, and the waiting is the whole of the punishment, and it has no end date because nobody set one, because nobody is administering it, because there is nobody at the other end of it at all.

Four minutes. One photograph. Two messages.

They have found a way to take a man's evenings for a year and spend nothing.

And his daughter is bare-headed on the street every day and does not know, because nobody has told her, because her mother decided not to and her father cannot form the sentence.

That is in my book under her mother's head, in handwriting about half the height of the line above it, and when I had written it I went out into the yard and stood there for a while in the dark.

40.

MINE. AGAIN. FOURTH TIME.

Still nothing. I went out and tried to get something and I could not.

In Tir I went out to be stopped.

I have never told anybody this and I am aware of how it sounds. I was eighteen and I had just finished the examination and I had three hundred and seventy women in a book in my bag and nothing of my own in any of them.

I did it on a Thursday because Thursdays are busy. I went to the big square at the top of the main road, the one with the metro mouth and the men selling socks, where there used to be a van parked on the corner by the bank, and I know there used to be because Hengameh told me which corner.

And I went with my head bare and my scarf folded in my bag, and I walked up and down that pavement for two hours and forty minutes.

I need to say what I was actually doing, because I have had to be honest with myself about it since.

I was not being brave. I want that struck out before anybody decides it. I was not making a point and there was nobody with me and I did not take a photograph of it and I have never once told it as a story.

I was trying to get a line in my own column.

That is all it was. I was eighteen and I had spent four years writing down what other women had paid, and I had worked out that I had paid nothing, and I could not stand it, and I went out to buy something so that I would be in the book I was keeping.

And nothing happened.

Nobody said anything to me. There was no van on that corner and I do not think there had been one for a long time. A woman at a bus stop with grey hair looked at my head for about two seconds and then looked away and I could not tell you what she was thinking and I have thought about her ever since.

A man selling socks called me sister and asked if I wanted socks. He called every woman on that pavement sister for two hours and forty minutes and I was the only one of us conducting an experiment.

At one point a police car went past and I stood still like an idiot and it went past.

And at about half past six I sat down on the step outside a sandwich place and understood what I had actually done, which is that I had gone out and tried to pay a debt at a counter that had been closed.

Because that is what it is. It is closed.

Not forgiven. Nobody forgave anybody. Not changed — the rule is exactly where it was, word for word, and the man with the folder came into our shop about eight weeks later with that rule in his hand.

Not announced, either. Nobody stood up anywhere and said, we have stopped collecting on that street at that hour. There is no such day. Khanom Ansari spent her whole life looking for the day they started and I have spent four years looking for the day they stopped and neither of those days exists.

The window is just shut. There is nobody behind it. And it can open again tomorrow and nobody will announce that either, and when it does, every woman in my book will have paid for a street that somebody else will have to buy back.

I walked home with my scarf still in my bag. My aunt was asleep in the chair with the serial on.

I wrote **mine, again, fourth time, still nothing** at the kitchen table and then I sat there for a while.

I had gone out at eighteen years old with my head bare to buy a line in a ledger. **I am aware that there are women in that book who would have given a great deal to be as bored as I was that afternoon.** I do not know whether what I did was the most selfish thing in the book or the only honest thing in it, and I have had a year and I still do not know.

41.

NOT A HEAD. A MAN CAME IN.

—

He came in on a Tuesday in Shahrivar at about half past four.

The bell went and I thought it was a customer and I came out of the back with wet hands.

He was about forty-five. A grey jacket, no tie. A cardboard folder under his arm with an elastic band round it, the kind that has a flap. He was not big and he was not frightening and he had a bad back, which I could see immediately because of the way he stood with one hand at the base of his spine.

There were two women in the shop with their heads uncovered. They put their scarves on. Nobody said anything. One of them did it so fast she pulled her own hair.

He said good afternoon and he asked for the person responsible for the premises.

My aunt came out. She had gloves on with colour on them. She took them off very slowly and put them in the bin and wiped her hands on a towel and said, that is me.

And then she said: sit down, you look like your back is hurting.

And he said, thank you, and sat down in the second chair, in a women's salon, with two customers in scarves pretending to read, and he put the folder on his knees.

He was polite the entire time. I want that understood, because it is the whole of what I have to say about him. He did not raise his voice. He did not threaten anybody with anything. He said *Khanom* every time he addressed her, and when my aunt offered him tea he said that was very kind of her and he would not, and he looked as though he meant it.

He was so polite that after about four minutes I began to feel that I had done something to him.

He said he was from a provincial office and he named it and I am not going to write the name because I never wrote any names.

He said he was doing a routine review of licensed premises in the district.

He asked how long she had held the licence. She told him. He wrote it down.

He asked whether the window treatment was in compliance. She said he was welcome to look. He looked, from inside, standing on nothing, from about a metre away, and said that it appeared satisfactory.

He asked about the hours. He asked whether any men were employed on the premises. He asked whether any events were held after hours.

And then he said: and you keep an appointment book.

And my aunt said: yes.

And he said: I would like to see the last three years of it.

And she said: I keep one year.

And he said: one year?

And she said: one year. Then I throw it away. I have the current one and the one before it. The rest go.

And he looked at her for a moment and wrote something down, and said: is that your practice.

And she said: that is my practice.

It was not. It had been eighteen years in a stack in that drawer and she had burned every single one of them in a barrel in the yard on a Thursday night four and a half years earlier, and the only person on earth who knew that was standing six feet away with wet hands.

He said he would like to collect the two books on Mehr the second, and he would appreciate it if they were ready.

And she said they would be ready.

And he thanked her, and he stood up with his hand at his back, and he said the thing I have never been able to get out of my head, which he said at the door, kindly, as a sort of apology for the inconvenience.

He said: it is nothing to do with you, Khanom. We are only trying to establish how it started.

42.

NOBODY. WE DID NOT OPEN.

—

On the twenty-fifth of Shahrivar a woman died in custody and this country came apart.

I am not going to write her name here.

I want to say why, because it is not squeamishness and it is not fear. It is that there are no names in my book. Not one, in five years, in three hundred and seventy-odd entries. My aunt burned eighteen years of names in a barrel and handed me a blank exercise book the next morning, and whatever she meant by it, what I built out of it was a record with no names in it at all.

And her name is in every mouth in this country and it will be in every mouth in this country for a hundred years. It does not need my book. My book is for the ones whose names are nowhere.

The shop did not open for a week.

I was eighteen. I will not describe that week, partly because everybody who was here has their own and does not need mine, and partly because I was not in it. I was in a flat with my aunt, who would not let me out of the door, and who did not sleep, and who sat up with the television on with the sound down the way she had in Aban two years before.

And on the fourth night of it she said something to me in the kitchen at about two in the morning, with her back to me, filling the kettle she had already filled.

She said: Baran. Where is the book.

And I said: in my bag.

And she said: not in the shop?

And I said no. I take it home every night.

And she stood there with the tap running into a full kettle for about four seconds.

And then she said: good.

And then she said: do not bring it into the shop again.

And I said, Khaleh, I have to write in it, I write in it at the till —

And she turned round and said: write it on something else and put it in the book at home.

And I said all right.

And she said: and if anybody asks you what you write at the till, it is the stock.

And I said all right.

And she said: say it.

And I said: it's the stock.

She nodded and turned the tap off and poured the whole kettle away and filled it again, and we did not say another word about it, and I did exactly what she told me for the next three weeks, which is why there is a loose piece of paper folded into the back of that book with nine entries on it in pencil that I never copied over.

There is a page in my book for that week and the first line says **nobody, we did not open** and the second line has a dash on it.

A dash. I could not write anything. Three hundred and seventy women, every single one of whose prices I had put down in that column for five years, and for that week I sat with the book open on the kitchen table and could not think of one unit that it went in.

43.

BARE. BARE. BARE. ALL OF THEM. SEVEN BEFORE NOON.

Nothing. A fine. Nothing. Nothing. A nephew. Nothing. Nothing.

We opened again and the shop was full and every head in it was bare.

Not some of them. All of them.

They did not come in and take their scarves off at the door. They came in off the pavement with nothing on their heads, one after another, all morning, and sat down and talked about ordinary things, and the painted window was still painted and the licence was still in the frame and a man was coming on the second of Mehr for the books.

My aunt did not say anything about it. She did the work. At about noon she went into the back and stayed there for a bit and came out again.

The man came on the second of Mehr at ten in the morning, exactly as he had said.

My aunt had the two appointment books on the counter with an elastic band round them.

He sat in the second chair again with his hand at his back and went through them. It took about twenty minutes. He had a pencil and he made a mark in his own folder every so often, and once he turned a book round and asked her what a word was, and she told him, and it was a woman's surname written badly.

And while he did it, with nothing else to do, he talked.

That is when he told me about the other countries. I have put the whole of it at the front of this part, because it does not belong in a morning with two appointment books on a counter and a woman under a dryer.

What belongs here is the end of it. He said it was a short list. For something that is supposed to be the natural order of things, a very short list. And he agreed, without any particular feeling, the way you agree about the weather, that it was getting shorter — and that nobody who had come off it had ever stood up and said so.

Then he shut the second book and put his hands flat on it and said:

Khanom, forgive me. These are appointments.

And my aunt said: yes.

He said: names, days, times.

She said: yes.

And he said: I am not looking for who came to the shop. I can see who came to the shop. I am trying to establish who began it.

And my aunt said: began what?

And he said — and this is exactly what he said, and I had my hand on the edge of the counter — he said:

This. On this street. Somebody must have been first.

And there was a silence of about three seconds, and then my aunt said, in the most ordinary voice in the world, the voice she used for the price of chicken:

I have been on this street for twenty-two years. Nobody was first.

And he said: somebody is always first, Khanom.

And she said: not with this.

He wrote something down. I do not know what. Then he put the elastic band round the two books and handed them back to her, which I had not expected, and said that he would be in touch if anything further was required, and he thanked her for her time, and at the door he said it was nothing to do with her, which was the second time he had said it, and I believe he believed it both times.

And then he was gone, and the bell went, and a woman under the dryer said, what did he want?

And my aunt said: nothing. He wants to know who started it.

And a woman in the end chair, who was about sixty and who had sat there all the way through it with a bare head and a magazine, said:

Started what? I'm sixty-one years old. I'm just hot.

And the whole shop went. Properly went. My aunt laughed until she had to sit down on the arm of the chair, which I had seen her do perhaps four times in five years.

That is the best thing anybody said in that shop in five years and I did not say it.

And I stood at the back with my hands in a towel and did not laugh, because I had just watched a man spend three weeks and two visits looking for a name, and I had the only book in that district with the answer in it, and the answer is that there is no name, and I was the only person in the room who could prove it.

44.

HERS. CUT TO THE JAW, ALL ONE LENGTH, AS IT HAS BEEN FOR FIVE YEARS.

She asked me to wash it. In five years she has never once asked.

Four days later, on the Saturday, after we had shut, my aunt sat down in the chair at the first basin and said: wash my hair.

I had washed her hair perhaps a hundred and twenty times in five years. Every second week. It was a thing we did at the end of a Saturday with the shutters down, the way you do the floor.

She had never asked for it. Not once. She would just be in the chair when I came through from the back, and I would do it, and neither of us would say anything about it, and nothing would come, and I would write **nothing** on the second line and that would be that.

This time she asked. She said the words. And she sat down in the first chair and not the second, which she never used, and she put her head back and shut her eyes before I had the towel on her.

And I knew. Not the thing — I did not know the thing yet. I knew that she had decided something and that she had picked the chair to do it in.

I want to put down what I understood later about why.

She did not know how it worked. I am certain of that. She never knew, and she never asked, and nobody in this whole book ever explained one single thing about it to me, including me.

But she had watched me for five years. She had watched a girl of fourteen turn into a girl of nineteen at that basin. She had seen me come out of the back room grey. She had taken me to a dentist about my jaw and listened to me say it was the examination and said *all right* in the voice you use when you have decided not to make somebody lie twice. She had told me, in the second year, out of nowhere, that I did not have to put everything in there. She had said, on a pavement with a cigarette, *I do not want you to do it, I want it done.*

She had worked out that I knew things. She did not know how and she did not care how. And she had waited five years, and a man had come into her shop twice with a folder looking for a name, and she had sat in a chair with her eyes shut and said wash my hair.

So I washed my aunt's hair.

I turned the water on and ran it over my wrist and it was right. I put the towel across her shoulders. I asked, is it good, and she said yes.

And I put my hand flat under the back of her head and lifted it off the porcelain.

She had a daughter.

I knew that. Everybody knew that. There is a name in our family that is said about twice a year, carefully, at the edge of other sentences. Parisa. I have known that name since I was four years old. I knew there had been a cousin and that she had died a long time before and that you did not ask, the same way you do not ask about anything else in a family, and by nineteen I had stopped even noticing that I had never been told how.

I was six when it happened. I do not remember it at all. There is no memory there to go looking in. There was a photograph on the shelf in the front room at some point and then there was not, and I cannot tell you what year it came down, because that is how those things work: nothing is announced.

She was twenty-one.

And then the rest of it came in, and I stood in my aunt's shop with my hand under her head and the water running and I did not say one word.

45.

**TO THE JAW. ALL ONE LENGTH. EVERY SIX WEEKS FOR
FOURTEEN YEARS.**

It is Parisa's length.

Here is what happened, in the order it came.

Parisa was twenty-one. She was out in the summer in the year I was six, in a month I will not write down because it does not need me to write it down, and she did not come back.

They had her for nine days before they would say so.

And when they would say so, there was a thing that had to be signed before they would let my aunt have her.

It said something about how she died that was not what happened.

My aunt signed it. She signed it in an office, on a Tuesday morning, sitting down, with a pen somebody handed her, and a man watching, and she read it first, and she knew exactly what it said, and she signed it.

And then there was a second part, which I did not know was a thing that happened to people until it came into me off my own aunt's scalp.

The same words had to go on the stone.

Not a note in a file. Not a form in a drawer. The sentence that is not true is cut into the stone over my cousin, in a cemetery I have been to twice in my life, and it is there now, and it will be there in a hundred years, and anybody who walks past it will read it and believe it, because why would they not.

My aunt chose the stone. She chose the lettering. She paid for it.

And it says the thing she was made to sign.

And the reason she signed it — this came in with everything else, in that flat way, like a telephone number — is that it was the ninth day and she wanted her daughter.

That is the whole of it. There was no other reason. A woman signed a lie about her own child's death because she had been standing in corridors for nine days and she wanted to take her home.

I had my hand under her head. The water was running over my wrist. She had her eyes shut and her breathing had not changed.

And then the last two things came, and they are the ones I have not been able to put down for a year.

Her hair.

Parisa wore it to the jaw. All one length. There is a photograph of her like that; it is the one that used to be on the shelf, and I have seen it, and I did not remember it until that minute at the basin, and then I remembered it completely.

My aunt wore hers long. Down her back, in a plait at work. I have seen pictures of that too and never once thought about it.

And on the night they welded the caps onto the boxes so that no woman could stand on one — the night I came down into the yard because I could smell it, and she was feeding eighteen years of appointment books into a barrel with a stick, and I said Khaleh what are you doing and she said go up — on that night, afterwards, she went into the bathroom and cut her own hair to the jaw with the kitchen scissors, badly, and would not let anybody fix it.

I wrote that in my book at fourteen. It is in there, in my first month, in a child's handwriting. **Cut to the jaw that morning, by herself, badly.**

I thought she was upset about the news.

Those appointment books had my cousin's name in them. Eighteen years of Tuesdays. A girl came to her mother's shop and had her hair done, dozens of times, and her mother wrote her name and the day and the hour in a book with a ring binding, in her own handwriting, because the licence requires it.

And on a Thursday night in Bahman, because a woman had stood on a box and been taken away and the city had welded the boxes shut, my aunt became frightened enough to burn the only record of her daughter's life that existed in this world.

And then she went upstairs and cut her hair to her daughter's length.

She made her own head into the record, because she had just destroyed the paper one.

And she has cut it to that exact length every six weeks since. Fourteen years, counting from the stone. Five of them in front of me. I have watched her do it at that mirror perhaps forty times and stand afterwards with her head a little on one side, looking at it for three seconds longer than a person looks at a haircut, and then say *right*, and go and put the kettle on.

I thought she was particular about it. I used to be irritated when she would not let me try anything with the front.

And the last thing.

She cannot be in that shop on her own.

Not frightened of anybody. Not of the street, not of men, not of the office with the folder. She simply cannot be in that room alone with the shutters down, and she has not been able to for fourteen years, and she has never said one word about it to anybody alive.

Which is why, when her sister went onto nights at the plant, my aunt was the one who asked for me.

I had believed my whole adolescence that I had been sent to her. I had told people that. My mother went onto nights, the journey was too long, I went to my aunt's — I have said that sentence a hundred times, including in the first page of this book.

She asked for me.

I have been in that shop for five years as a person for a woman not to be alone with, and nobody ever told me, and she fed me, and taught me a trade, and took me to a dentist, and bought me a cake on a corner like I was nine, and never once said why.

I finished washing her hair.

I did the second wash. I towelled it. I asked, is it still good, and she said yes.

And then she opened her eyes and looked at me in the glass and said one word.

She said: **Well?**

And I said: I know.

And she said: good.

And neither of us said one further thing about it, that night or ever, and she cut her own hair to the jaw at the mirror six weeks later, all one length, and stood and looked at it, and said right, and went and put the kettle on.

46.

THREE HUNDRED AND SEVENTY-FOUR.

A hundred and thirty-one. And one page I took out.

He came back on a Thursday in the middle of Mehr. Nobody had telephoned. The bell went just before ten and it was him with the folder under his arm and his hand at the base of his back.

My aunt was not there. She had gone to the wholesaler on the main road for colour and she was forty minutes away at best.

There were three women in the shop, all bare-headed, and they put their scarves on, and one of them put it on wrong and left it.

He said good morning and he asked for the person responsible for the premises and I said she was out and he said he would wait, if that was all right, and I said of course, and he sat down in the second chair.

And then he said: it is you who writes at the counter.

I said yes.

He said: the stock?

And I said: the stock.

And he said: hm.

And then he said, not unkindly, looking at his folder and not at me: how old are you?

I said nineteen.

He said: and you have been here how long?

I said five years.

And he nodded, and he said — and I am putting this down exactly because it is the last thing anybody in authority has ever said to me:

He said: then you have seen the whole of it, haven't you.

And I said yes.

And he said: so you tell me, then. Who was first?

And I want to describe what happened in me, because it took about two seconds and it has governed the rest of my life.

I thought: he is not lying. He genuinely wants a name. He has been given a number by somebody above him that he cannot account for, and he has spent weeks on this street going into shops with a bad back, and he has read two years of a hairdresser's appointments, and he is sitting in a chair in a women's salon on a Thursday morning asking a girl of nineteen for a name, because in his entire training and in his entire office and on every form he has ever filled in, **a thing has a cause and a cause has a name.**

And he is not going to get one. Not from me, not from anybody, not ever, because it does not exist.

And then I thought about my book.

Three hundred and seventy-four heads. A hundred and thirty-one with something in the second column. Not one name in any of it. Not one line connecting any two women in it. Khanom Ansari did not know Hengameh. Hengameh did not know the teacher. Shaghayegh had sat in a chair next to at least four of the others and talked to them about rice.

And every single one of them paid alone, and nobody thanked one of them, and nobody will, and there is no office anywhere whose job it is to add up the second column, because the cases sit in different courts and different provinces under different articles — a fine here, a suspended sentence there, an administrative matter, an expulsion, a message to a husband's telephone — and the only reason no number exists is that no building was ever built to hold one.

And I had it. In a bag, on a hook, four feet behind him.

So I went and got it.

I went into the back and took it out of my bag and stood with it in my hands for a moment, and then I opened it at the front, at the first page, where I had written my own name at fourteen in the top corner the way children label a schoolbook, with the year next to it in a loopy hand.

And underneath my name, because I had ruled the columns on every page including that one, there was a line, and the first column was empty and the second column was empty.

I tore that page out. One page. I folded it twice and put it in the pocket of my tunic.

Not because I was frightened. I have been through this every day since and I am not going to make it prettier than it is. There were two reasons and they are both true and they do not sit well together.

The first is that the book has no names in it. That is what it is. My aunt burned a book full of names and gave me a blank one the next morning, and whatever she meant by it, a record with no names in it was the thing I built, and my own name on the front page was the only thing in five years that broke it. Taking it out made the book honest.

And the second is that I have paid nothing, and I was not going to be bound in with them.

Then I came out and I gave it to him.

I put it on his knees on top of his folder and I said: this is what we have got.

And he opened it.

And I stood there and watched a man in a grey jacket read the first page, and then turn it, and then turn it, and then stop turning and go back, and read one line twice.

And he did not say anything for a long time.

Then he said: there are no names in this.

And I said: no.

And he said: what is the second line?

And I said: what it cost her.

He looked at it for a while longer. He got to the end — it does not take long, it is four hundred lines — and then he went back to the middle and read two pages properly, which I could tell because of how long it took him.

And then he closed it and sat with both hands flat on the cover, and he said, in a completely different voice from the one he had used about the window and the hours:

What am I supposed to do with this?

And I said: I don't know.

And he said: there is no name in it.

And I said: there isn't one.

And he said — and this is the end of it, this is the whole of what happened, there was no argument and nobody raised their voice and nothing was settled —

He said: then there is nothing for me to write.

And I said: no.

And he sat there with his hands on it for a bit. One of the women under the dryer turned a page of her magazine. Out on the street somebody was backing a van and the beeper was going.

And then he put the book inside his folder and did the elastic band round it, and he stood up with his hand at his back, and he said: I will need to take this.

And I said: I know.

And he said thank you, which I have thought about ever since, and he went out, and the bell went, and I heard him cough once on the pavement.

My aunt came back twenty minutes later with four boxes of colour and said the man had put the price up again.

I said: he took the book.

And she put the boxes on the counter and straightened them, and said: did he say anything?

And I said: he said thank you.

And she looked at the boxes for a bit and then she said: well. **They are always very polite when there is nothing in it for them.**

And then she asked me to put the kettle on, and I did, and we did four heads that afternoon, and I wrote them on a piece of paper at the till because there was no longer a book to write them in.

I have the page. It is folded twice and it is in a tin with a hinge that was my grandmother's, and it has my name on it, and a year, and two empty columns.

GLOSSARY

chador [chaa-DOR] — a single large piece of cloth, usually black, held closed at the front and covering the body from the head down. Worn over other clothes, and worn by choice by some women and as a uniform by others.

Khaleh [khaa-LEH] — mother's sister. A maternal aunt is called *khaleh*, on its own or followed by her name. A father's sister is a different word.

Khanom [KHAA-nom] — madam; the ordinary respectful form of address to a woman, used with her family name or on its own. A girl of fourteen would call every customer this.

Nowruz [no-ROOZ] — the new year, at the spring equinox. The weeks before it are the busiest of the year in a hair salon, because everybody wants to be new for it.

Ramadan [ra-ma-DAAN] — the month of fasting.

THE MONTHS

The year begins at the spring equinox. The twelve months, in order, with the ones used in this book marked:

Farvardin [far-var-DEEN] · spring begins · *used* **Ordibehesht** [or-dee-be-HESHT] · *used* **Khordad** [khor-DAAD] · *used* **Tir** [TEER] · summer; the hottest weeks, with Mordad · *used* **Mordad** [mor-DAAD] · *used* **Shahrivar** [shah-ree-VAR] · *used* **Mehr** [MEHR] · autumn begins; the school year begins · *used* **Aban** [aa-BAAN] · *used* **Azar** [aa-ZAR] · *used* **Dey** [DAY] · winter · *used* **Bahman** [bah-MAAN] · *used* **Esfand** [es-FAND] · the last month; the year ends at its close · *used*

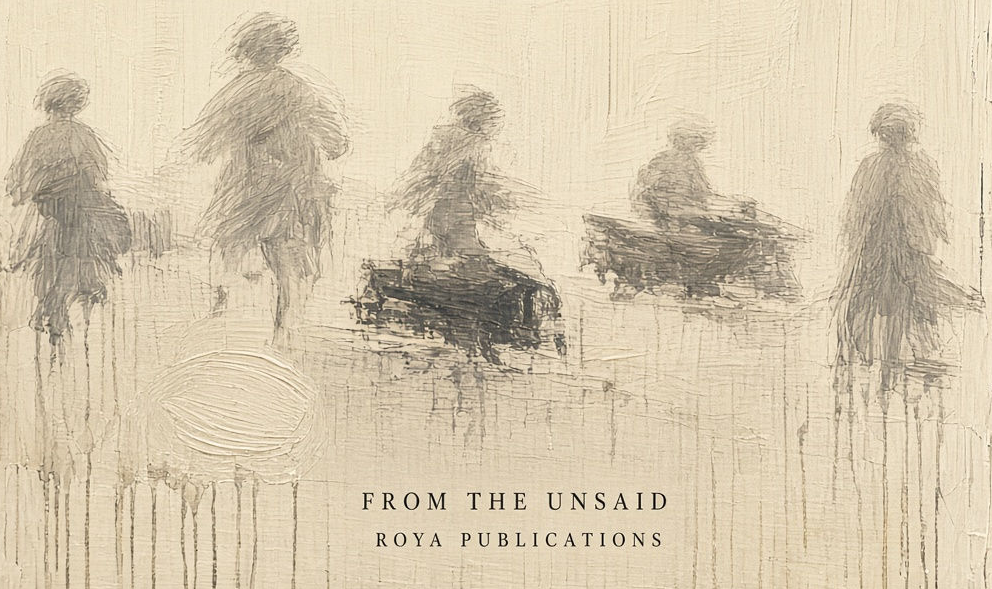
A hair salon in southern Tehran. The street window is painted over, because that is the law. Inside it, every woman takes her scarf off. Outside it, every woman puts it back on.

Baran is fourteen when she starts work at the basin. Her aunt hands her an old exercise book and says: write down what is there. Nobody wants it. Write it down anyway.

And when her hands are in the water, she begins to know what each head has already cost the woman wearing it.

By the time she is nineteen it is the only place on earth where any of it has been added up. Then a man comes to the shop with a folder, and he is polite, and he wants to know who started it.

Nobody lowered the price. They paid the same thing every time and got less and less for it.



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